

PRESUPPOSITIONS

RECOVERING THE BIBLICAL WORLDVIEW OF
GOD'S REDEMPITIVE PLAN

THE RESTORATION SERIES
BOOK 1

DR. TIM JAMES



Presuppositions: Recovering the Biblical Worldview of God's Redemptive Plan

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Hebrew and Greek studies reference *Strong's Concordance* and publicly available interlinear tools (BibleHub.com, BlueLetterBible.org).

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Tree of Life

*A symbol of the Holy Spirit's
presence and the
restoration of all things.
(Acts 3:21)*

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



I was raised in a Roman Catholic home—the eldest of five children, educated at a Catholic parochial school through eighth grade, and shaped by a family whose faith was sincere, disciplined, and devoted. My father, a Presbyterian, agreed to have his children raised Catholic as a condition of marrying my mother—a decision that profoundly influenced my early spiritual formation.

Later, my wife Jeanne—whose childhood spanned Catholic and Lutheran backgrounds—and I raised our sons in a non-denominational evangelical framework, prioritizing Christ-centered education and discipleship over denominational allegiance.

I trained as a surgeon and served as a medical missionary, fulfilling a lifelong desire to combine gospel-driven compassion with practical service. Over the years—between hospital work, raising a family, crossing oceans under sail, and many nights in Scripture—the Lord prepared me not only to care for the body but to speak to the

soul. What began as a personal pursuit of biblical clarity has grown into a focused mission: to help believers understand God's revelation concerning resurrection, Christ's return, and the restoration of all things.

I write today as a follower of Jesus Christ and an apostolic Christian—not in the modern denominational sense, but in the biblical one. My allegiance is to the risen Lord, His Word, and His Spirit. I teach that salvation is by grace through faith, though it can be forfeited by willful apostasy. I affirm the literal bodily resurrection of the righteous at Christ's parousia, the glorification of the living who belong to Him, and the literal fulfillment of God's promises to Israel. The New Jerusalem is a physical reality—a restored Eden where heaven and earth are united.

My theology is shaped primarily by Scripture, informed by decades of scholarship—but always tested against the text itself. I do not strive to comply with any denomination; I only point to the Kingdom.

— Dr. Tim James

ABSTRACT

Presuppositions is an academic appeal for introspective re-examination, addressing how specific English mistranslations have given rise to entrenched false teachings that have reshaped modern Western Christianity. While salvation itself may not always be in jeopardy, the meaning and application of God's Word often are. The author seeks to restore intellectual honesty by guiding readers back to Scripture and away from centuries of cultural distortion. Serving as a springboard into *The Restoration Series*, *Presuppositions* challenges readers to uncover blind spots, test long-held denominational and traditional assumptions, and cultivate a more precise and faithful understanding of the Bible.



THESIS

This book and the study that formed it rests on three pillars:

1. **Textual Integrity:** Prioritize Scripture over systems, allowing the biblical text to speak for itself rather than forcing it into inherited frameworks.
2. **Linguistic Accuracy:** Return to the original Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic to correct mistranslations.
3. **Theological Coherence:** Read the Bible as intended by its original authors.



METHODOLOGY

Presuppositions is rooted in Scripture—both in content and approach. The methodology is simple: let the Bible interpret itself. Instead of relying on fallible commentaries or confessional traditions, the plain meaning of the text in its original language and context is paramount.

God did not inspire His Word to confuse or obscure its meaning. Sometimes, understanding it requires careful study and diligence. Readers are encouraged to adopt the Berean model (Acts 17:11): examine everything in light of Scripture.

Interlinear tools such as BibleHub, Blue Letter Bible, and Logos are used to examine key terms like *shamayim*, *Sheol*, *parousia*, *thlipsis*, *orgē*, and *apantēsis*—revealing mistranslations and correcting long-standing theological distortions. Biblical truth is too important to outsource to teachers, preachers, denominations, or tradition.



INTRODUCTION

I once had a patient who proudly told me:

"I've read the Bible cover to cover thirty-nine times—and every time, I discover something I've never seen before."

Her words stuck with me. The Bible isn't a flat manual; it's a layered, living revelation. It speaks new things to us — if we're willing to let go of what we think we already know.

— Dr. Tim James

Eschatology vs. New Beginnings

While eschatology studies the “end times,” there isn’t a single widely recognized term for the study of new beginnings. Restoration, renewal, and the ushering in of a new era all fall under this theme. Revelation 20 is the only passage in Scripture that discusses a 1,000-year period, so it deserves careful attention.

In Revelation 20:1-3, a mighty angel comes to earth holding the key to the bottomless pit and a great chain. He seizes the dragon (Satan) and binds him for a thousand years.

In verses 4-6, John sees thrones occupied by those entrusted with judgment: martyrs who remained faithful to Christ, refused the mark of the beast, and resisted worshiping the antichrist. This marks the First Resurrection, tied to Jesus’ resurrection as the Firstfruit.

By verses 7-10, the thousand years are complete, and Satan is released. He deceives the unrighteous nations—Gog and Magog—for a second attack on Jerusalem. But God intervenes: fire from heaven consumes the attackers, and Satan is cast into the lake of fire alongside the antichrist and the false prophet.

Finally, in verses 11-15, the White Throne judgment occurs: all unrighteous are condemned, including Death, Hades, and even the sea. The righteous—those resurrected and “changed” on the Day of the Lord—are exempt, their names written in the Lamb’s Book of Life.

Millennialism refers to this 1,000-year reign of Christ, a time when God restores all things to their intended order. Different theological interpretations exist:

- **Premillennialism:** Christ returns before a literal thousand-year reign on earth.
- **Postmillennialism:** Christ returns after a period of global spiritual triumph led by the Church.
- **Amillennialism:** The 1,000 years is symbolic of the

current church age, which has already lasted roughly 2,000 years.

Today is your opportunity for a fresh start. This book is a primer for self-examination—about what you believe regarding God, salvation, death, resurrection, reign, restoration, and eternity. Do the work of introspection. What we believe about the end shapes how we live now. Biblical truth is too important to outsource to teachers, preachers, denominations, or tradition.

I pray this book helps you realign your reading of Scripture with God's redemptive heart. The Day of the Lord is coming. The King will return. Be ready—on His terms, not ours.

*“Open my eyes, that I may behold
wondrous things out of your law.”*

– Psalm 119:18



TABLE OF CONTENTS

<i>Preface</i>	xix
<i>Bible Primer</i>	xxi
<i>What Is The Day of the Lord About?</i>	xxiii
Left blank on purpose.	1
1. Why Presuppositions Matter	4
<i>Seeing Scripture Clearly Starts with Examining Our Assumptions</i>	
A blank page for your notes	11
2. The Devil's PsyOps: Cognitive Dissonance & Confirmation Bias	12
<i>How Satan Weaponizes the Mind to Resist Truth and Reframe Reality</i>	
A blank page for your notes	19
3. Understanding Covenants — A Biblical Framework	20
<i>Tracing God's Unbreakable Promises From Eden to the End of the Age</i>	
4. Rereading Genesis 1:1 — Earth and Sky, Not Heaven	30
<i>Recovering What the Bible Actually Says About Creation's Opening Line</i>	
5. God's Desire to Dwell Among Us — From Eden to New Jerusalem	34
<i>The Thread of Divine Presence Running Through the Entire Redemption Story</i>	
Blank page for your notes	41
6. Israel vs. The Gentile Church	42
<i>Why God's Covenant With Israel Still Stands — and Always Will</i>	
Blank page for your notes	49
7. Language Matters — Shamayim, Sheol, Gehenna, Paradise	50
<i>How the Bible's Original Words Clarify the Afterlife and Judgment</i>	
8. The Kingdom Now and Not Yet	60
<i>Exposing the Error of Present-Day Kingdom Theology and Restoring the Promise of Christ's Future Reign</i>	
9. Reading the Prophets as Jesus Did	66
<i>Recovering the Forward-Looking Lens of Biblical Prophecy</i>	
10. Recovering Apostolic Expectation — What the Early Church Believed	72
<i>Restoring the Hope of Resurrection, Return, and Kingdom</i>	
11. Refuting Popular Errors — A Biblical Checklist	78
<i>How to Spot—and Correct—Dangerous Assumptions</i>	

Blank page for your notes	85
12. Resources for Honest Bible Study	86
<i>Tools, Habits, and Study Methods for Reading the Bible Without Filtered Assumptions</i>	
13. Let Scripture Define Your Framework	92
<i>An Invitation to Lifelong Reformation in Light of God's Redemptive Plan</i>	
14. Bible Study in a World of Misinformation	94
<i>Guarding Against Theological Drift and Doctrinal Assumptions</i>	
Blank page for your notes	97
15. Final Thoughts: The Return of Our King	98
<i>A Glimpse Into the Restoration Series: Foundations of the World to the Renewal of All Things</i>	
Acknowledgments	103
A Glimpse Ahead:	105
<i>The Restoration Series Book Titles</i>	107
<i>Glossary of Key Biblical Terms</i>	109
<i>Appendix A - Six Major Covenants</i>	113
<i>Appendix B: "In That Day" and "At That Time"</i>	121
<i>Appendix C: The UP/DN Scriptural Journey of the Dead</i>	125
<i>Thematic Structure Index</i>	129
<i>Afterword</i>	131

PREFACE

Presuppositions is the first volume in *The Restoration Series*. This book is for serious students of Scripture—teachers, pastors, seekers, and anyone willing to test what they’ve been taught. You may discover that some ideas handed down by tradition, Sunday School, or even from the pulpit differ from what the original biblical authors intended.

This is not a book of arguments. It is a call to clarity. Its purpose is to recover the biblical worldview—the framework that shaped the apostles’ hope, the prophets’ warnings, and the Messiah’s mission. That worldview has been buried beneath layers of tradition, mistranslation, and modern theological systems.

Presuppositions is designed to provide relief for those frustrated by contradiction and confusion. Why are there so many denominations? Why so many Bible translations? Which one reflects the truth? This book challenges long-held assumptions—not for novelty, but for realignment. Understanding presuppositions is the first step.

Inside, you will explore the original meanings of terms such as

shamayim, *Sheol*, *Paradise*, *parousia*, *thlipsis*, *orgē*, *apantēsis*, and *episunagógē*. You will see how revered translations like the KJV often mislead and contribute to longstanding theological disputes. Historical and cultural context is also essential: why does Western theology often differ from the rest of the Christian world?

My goal is to guide you toward the Berean model (Acts 17:11): examine everything in light of Scripture. Read, pray, and think for yourself. Don't leave your understanding—or your eternity—to someone else's opinions. Take your faith seriously. Discover truth on your own, and give God your all.

— *Dr. Tim James*



BIBLE PRIMER

Presuppositions is about clarity.

For many sincere believers, the Bible feels confusing. Prophecies seem disconnected. The Old and New Testaments can feel like separate stories. Assumptions about heaven, the Church, or the end times are accepted without question.

This book invites you to slow down and start at the beginning. Drawing from the biblical narrative — from Genesis 1:1 to the return of the King, *Presuppositions* uncovers the covenantal, creation-rooted, kingdom-bound framework that shaped the apostles' faith and the hope of the early Church.

The Bible is not fragmented. Its story is coherent—and more glorious than we've been told.



WHAT IS THE DAY OF THE LORD ABOUT?

“For the day of the Lord is near upon all the nations.

*As you have done, it shall be done to you;
your deeds shall return on your own head.”*

— Obadiah 1:15

The Day of the Lord is the climactic day of Scripture—the convergence of God’s judgment, promises, Messiah, and Kingdom. The prophets heralded it, pleaded for it, and proclaimed it. It begins when heaven shakes, the earth trembles, the sun darkens, and God’s fury falls on all that is evil and unrighteous. Yet He shelters, protects, and rewards all who endure faithfully and walk in righteousness.

Scriptural Foundations: The Day of the Lord

The phrase “the Day of the Lord” appears repeatedly across both Testaments. It is a divinely orchestrated **season of cosmic and earthly intervention**—a time when God’s justice, mercy, and kingdom purposes converge. The prophets and apostles describe it consistently:

Old Testament Highlights:

- **Isaiah 13:6-13** — A day of wrath and fierce anger; the heavens tremble, the stars and constellations do not give their light.
- **Joel 2:1-11** — Darkness and gloom accompany the arrival of God's army.
- **Amos 5:18-20** — A warning against those longing for it; it will be darkness, not light.
- **Zephaniah 1:14-18** — Distress, devastation, and divine fire will mark the day.

New Testament Highlights:

- **John 16:33** — Tribulation comes in this age, but Christ overcomes the world.
- **Acts 14:22** — Believers must endure many tribulations to enter God's kingdom.
- **Romans 5:3-9** — Suffering produces endurance; through Christ we are saved from God's wrath.
- **1 Thessalonians 1:10, 5:9** — Jesus delivers us from the wrath to come.
- **Revelation 14:14-20** — The double harvest: the righteous are gathered, the wicked judged in the winepress of God's wrath.

(The Chart Listing Major Old and New Testament Verses About the Day of the Lord is on the next page.)

The Day of the Lord in the OT and NT

Scripture	Summary
Isaiah 13:6–13	Day of wrath and cosmic upheaval; God judges Babylon; stars and constellations darken.
Joel 2:1–11	Day of darkness and gloom; God's army arrives to execute judgment.
Amos 5:18–20	A day longed for by the wicked becomes darkness, not light.
Zephaniah 1:14–18	Day of distress, devastation, and divine fire against the rebellious.
Acts 2:20	Peter cites Joel; cosmic signs precede the great and awesome day.
1 Thessalonians 5:2	Paul: the day comes like a thief in the night, sudden and unexpected.
2 Thessalonians 2:1–4	The Day has not yet come; it will follow rebellion and the revelation of the lawless one.
Revelation 6:17	Great day of God's wrath; none can withstand it.
Revelation 14:14–20	Dual harvest imagery: righteous gathered, wicked judged; angels execute divine justice.
Matthew 24:30–31	Christ gathers His elect at His return.
Revelation 19:11–21	Christ leads a divine military campaign, defeating the Beast and his armies.
Revelation 20:1–6	Satan is bound; the Millennial Kingdom begins; First Resurrection inaugurated.

Why Don't More Christians Talk About It?

If your church experience is like mine, you've probably never heard a sermon on the Day of the Lord—or if you did, it was a rare occasion. Modern teaching often reduces that Day to fear-mongering about “the end of the world.”

Meanwhile, celebrity preachers and bestselling authors have hijacked the most monumental day in human history and turned it into a marketing product. They peddle fear, dazzle with speculative charts, and leave people more confused than equipped. That is deception. They have corrupted faith in Jesus Christ into an enterprise of prognostication—not far removed from occult fortune-telling.

This book exists to change that. Let's start here:

“Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching. The time has come when people reject sound teaching. Having itching ears, they seek out teachers who cater to their passions. They have turned away from listening to the truth and wandered off to the deceptive teachings of cutesy pastors. ...[7] (Paul:) I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. [8] Henceforth there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will award to me on that day. — not only to me but also to all who have loved His appearing.”

— 2 Timothy 4:2-4, 7-8 (paraphrased)

We will trace **every mention of the Day of the Lord in Scripture**—its signs, seals, chronology, warnings, and promises. Above all, we will follow the King Himself, Jesus the Messiah, as He breaks the seals, shakes the heavens, rescues His people, and establishes His Kingdom.

The journey begins here—with eyes open, hearts ready, and the Word of God as our guide.

The Bible uses the phrase “the Day of the Lord” over and over—from the prophets of the Old Testament to the apostles of the New. It is a consistent and cohesive term. Yet today, few in the Church understand what the phrase means, where it begins, how long it lasts, or what role the Church plays within it.

This foundational chapter will uncover the depth of this critical term, provide historical and prophetic context, and explain why recovering a biblical understanding of the Day of the Lord is essential to restoring the Christian hope.

The Problem with Modern Eschatology

Modern eschatology, especially in Western evangelical circles, has surrendered its anchor to the seabed of Chaos. Influenced by sensationalist predictions, fictionalized apocalyptic novels, and heavily marketed prophecy charts, many believers operate with a fragmented understanding of the end times. Terms like “rapture,” “tribulation,” and “millennium” are thrown around without anchoring them to their scriptural foundation.

The phrase “the Day of the Lord” is consistently used throughout both Testaments, and yet it has largely been ignored—or misunderstood. This book begins by restoring this central term to its rightful place.

“The Day of the Lord”

The Day of the Lord is not a twenty-four-hour period. Nor is it the end of the world. Instead, it is the beginning of the New Age, which will position us in the eternal presence of God Himself.

It will be a divinely orchestrated season—a sequence of cosmic and earthly interventions that begins with the judgment of the wicked and culminates in the renewal of all things.

The Phrase in the Old Testament

The first occurrence of the phrase “the Day of the Lord” (Hebrew: *yom YHWH*) is found in the writings of the early prophets:

The Day of the Lord signals divine intervention—but that is only bad for the unrighteous whose names are not in the Lamb’s book of life. For the righteous dead in Paradise, and the righteous alive on the surface of the earth, it is the first day of eternity with our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

Get It Right!

The righteous may endure *tribulation* (thlipsis)—the pressure of persecution in this age—but they are explicitly spared from *wrath* (orgé)—God’s judicial punishment poured out in the Day of the Lord.

- **John 16:33** — “*In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world.*”
- **Acts 14:22** — “*...through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God.*”
- **Romans 5:3** — “*We rejoice in our sufferings [thlipsis], knowing that suffering produces endurance...*”
- **2 Timothy 3:12** — “*Indeed, all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted...*”

The Righteous Will Avoid God’s Wrath (Gr. Orgé)

- **Romans 5:9** — “*Since, therefore, his blood has now justified us, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath (orgé) of God.*”
- **1 Thessalonians 1:10** — “*...Jesus who delivers us from the wrath (orgé) to come.*”
- **1 Thessalonians 5:9** — “*For God has not destined us for wrath (orgé), but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ...*”

Apocalyptic Imagery: The Two Harvests on the Day of the Lord

Revelation 14:14-20

- **Harvest of Righteous** — Wheat — Christ sends angels to gather His elect (the First Resurrection): “[15] *And another angel came out of the temple, calling with a loud voice to him who sat on the cloud, ‘Put in your sickle, and reap, for the hour to reap has come, for the harvest of the earth is fully ripe.’* [16] *So he who sat on the cloud swung his sickle across the earth and the earth was reaped.*”
- **Harvest of Wicked** — Grapes — Then, the wicked are separated and judged (the harvest of wrath, orgé): “[18] *And another angel came out from the altar... ‘Put in your sickle and gather the clusters from the vine of the earth, for its grapes are ripe.’* [19] *So the angel swung his sickle... and threw it into the great winepress of the wrath of God.*”

Matthew 13:36-43

- **Wheat and Weeds/Tares** — [38] *“the field is the world, the good seed is sons of the kingdom, weeds are sons of the evil one, [39] the enemy sower is the devil. [40] at the end of the age. [42] Jesus will send angels to gather out of His kingdom all causes of sin and lawbreakers, and throw them into the fiery furnace, weeping and gnashing of teeth. [43] Then the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom.”*)

Matthew 13:47-50

- **Parable of the Net** — [47] *“The kingdom is the net, full of fish of every kind. [48] Sorted; the good put into containers, but the bad thrown away. [49] So it will be at the end of the age. Angels will separate the evil from the righteous [50] and throw evil into the fiery furnace; weeping and gnashing of teeth.”*)

Matthew 24:30-31

- **Gathering the Elect** — [30] *“Jesus coming; [31] He will send out angels with a loud trumpet call, to gather His elect.”*

2 Thessalonians 1:7-9

- **Mighty Angels** — ([7] *“Jesus appears with His mighty angels in flaming fire, [8] inflicting vengeance on those who do not know God or obey the gospel. [9] eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord.”*

Revelation 19:13,15

- **Jesus** — ([13] *“robe dipped in blood, The Word of God. [14] And the armies of heaven following Him on white horses. [15] He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”*

The Resurrection: The Harvest of the Righteous on the Day of the Lord

The resurrection of the righteous dead and the “changing” of the righteous alive will happen on the Day of the Lord, as Christ is descending from His heavenly abode, and is followed by His army of angels. Therefore, all the righteous will already have their immortal glorified bodies *before* the Bowls of God’s wrath are poured out — and thus be immune from suffering or death as a consequence of “the wrath of the Lamb.”

The Coming of the Messiah and The Day of the Lord (Already, But Not Yet)

In Jewish expectation, the Day of the Lord was associated with the

arrival of God's Anointed One—the Messiah—who will judge the wicked and establish God's rule on earth.

In the first century, however, the Messiah came as a suffering servant, not as a conquering king. Jesus inaugurated the Kingdom of God, but He doesn't take possession until the Day of the Lord.

Thus, the early Church lived in a state of prophetic tension. They recognized that Jesus' resurrection and ascension were but the opening acts — and that the King would one day (the Day of the Lord), return to take possession of the Kingdom of God.

Peter, quoting Joel 2, declared at Pentecost:

“The sun shall be turned to darkness and the moon to blood, before the day of the Lord comes, the great and magnificent day.”

— Acts 2:20

The early believers understood that the Day of the Lord was still in the future. Yet they lived with urgency and hope and faithful endurance even unto death.

Paul and the Day of the Lord

Paul reinforced this in his letters:

- **1 Thessalonians 5:2** – “For you yourselves are fully aware that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night.”
- **2 Thessalonians 2:1-4** – Paul urged believers not to be deceived into thinking the Day has already come. Paul taught that Day will not arrive until (1) “the rebellion comes first, and (2) the man of lawlessness is revealed.”

In Paul's theology, the Day of the Lord was the defining moment

when Christ will return, He will raise the dead, He will overthrow the rebellious powers, and He will begin His reign.

Sequential (7 Phases)

Far from being a sudden cataclysmic event that ends history in an instant, the Day of the Lord unfolds in phases and concludes with the righteous living with God in the New Jerusalem for eternity:

1. **The Resurrection and Glorification of the Righteous** (*1 Thessalonians 4:16; Revelation 20:4-6*). At the parousia, the righteous dead are raised in glorified, immortal bodies. This is the First Resurrection—the opening phase of the Day of the Lord. This is the inauguration of the saints' royal destiny—they are raised not merely to life, but to rule. The righteous saints are caught up to meet the returning King in the air — not removed to heaven, but to accompany Him as He begins His visible reign on earth.
2. **The Harvest of the Wicked by Angelic Reapers** (*Matthew 13:41-42; Revelation 14:17-20*). With the righteous gathered and secured, angelic reapers are sent out to harvest the weeds — all who cause sin and practice lawlessness. Their removal is not just punitive—it is purgative. The Kingdom of God cannot be inherited by the wicked (1 Corinthians 6:9), and so this harvest clears the field for righteousness. The imagery is graphic — the wicked are thrown into the “winepress of God’s wrath,” a metaphor for the terrifying judgment that follows.
3. **The Return of Christ to Earth: A Military Campaign** (*Zechariah 14:4; Revelation 19:11-21*). The King does not descend directly to the Mount of Olives. Instead, Scripture hints at a broader, multi-stage procession. **Isaiah 19:1** declares: “Behold, the Lord is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt...” This prophetic entrance signals the start of a visible, geographical campaign. From Egypt to Bozrah

(*Isaiah 63:1-6*), then up through Edom and into Jerusalem — a prophetic, military sequence.

NOTE: Christ's descent is not directly to the Mount of Olives; it is a military campaign of redemption and vengeance that begins in Egypt. He rides from Egypt, through Bozrah, stained with the blood of His enemies (*Isaiah 63:1-6*), and finally sets foot on the Mount of Olives in Jerusalem (*Zechariah 14:4*). Before He arrives at the Mount of Olives, Christ advances across the land with power and vengeance. His presence shakes the nations; His purpose is to reclaim what is rightfully His and to recover the remnant of Israeli refugees.

4. The Defeat of Antichrist and His Global Coalition

(*Revelation 19:19-21*; *2 Thessalonians 2:8*). The Beast, his armies, and the kings of the earth assemble to make war against the Lamb. But they are no match. King Jesus destroys them with the breath of His mouth and the sword of His word. This is not merely a human war — it is also a supernatural war involving all who align themselves with the dragon, both human and elohim.

Interlude: The Angelic Armies — The Overlooked Campaign

(*Joel 3:11*; *Revelation 12:7-9*; *Isaiah 13:3-5*)

While Christ descends and begins His terrestrial advance, the hosts of heaven are not idle. Angelic armies — “holy ones,” “mighty ones,” and “reapers” — sweep across the earth and skies, executing judgment. These are intelligent, holy warriors empowered to cleanse and reclaim dominion (*Psalms 82*; *Daniel 10*). Their targets include demonic strongholds, rebellious powers in the heavenlies (*Ephesians 6:12*), and the earthly coalition under the Beast. Read *Isaiah 13:4b* — “The LORD has mustered His army for battle.” And *Joel 3:14* — “Multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision!” This is the cosmic cleansing

that will precede Christ's arrival in Jerusalem. It is a war of supernatural proportions.

5. **The Binding of Satan and the Inauguration of the Millennial Kingdom** (*Revelation 20:1-6*). With the Beast defeated and the spiritual powers crushed, Satan himself is bound and thrown into the abyss. The age of deception ends. Christ begins His visible reign on earth — the long-awaited Messianic Kingdom. With the serpent bound, the deceiver silenced, and the usurpers crushed, the earth can finally enter into its long-awaited Sabbath rest.
6. **The Installation of the Saints as Co-Rulers** (*Daniel 7:27; Revelation 5:10*). Those who shared in the First Resurrection now take up positions of authority. Kingship is not symbolic. Their thrones are not metaphors. These resurrected saints will judge nations, administer justice, and reign under the authority of the Great King, fulfilling the promise of **Revelation 2:26-27**. The glorified saints are assigned foundational roles — judging, governing, and shepherding the nations under Christ's leadership.
7. **The Final Judgment (Great White Throne)** (*Revelation 20:11-15*). At the end of the thousand years, the unrighteous dead are raised for judgment. This is not resurrection to life, but to condemnation. The books are opened, and every deed is laid bare. Death and Hades are cast into the lake of fire. This sequence is drawn from Scripture. Each step builds on the last. And it all fits under the banner of the Day of the Lord. This is not part of the First Resurrection, but a distinct event for the unrighteous dead. It concludes the Day of the Lord and ushers in the New Creation.

Why This Matters

Understanding the Day of the Lord as a biblical sequence restores

clarity to Christian eschatology, reunifying scattered doctrines—such as resurrection, judgment, kingdom, and reward—into a cohesive vision.

More importantly, it shifts the Church's posture. Rather than hoping to escape earth through a secret rapture, the Church is to prepare for glory. The saints are destined to be glorified, enthroned, and commissioned to reign *with* Christ. This vision demands readiness, righteousness, and resilience. It restores the weight and wonder of our calling:

“If we endure, we will also reign with Him.”
— 2 Timothy 2:12

Preview of the Restoration to Come

This First Chapter opens the door to the grand project of *The Day of the Lord* Volume I. In the chapters ahead, we will explore:

- The First Resurrection and its distinction from resuscitation
- The unveiling of the sons of God
- The defeat of hostile powers in heaven and on earth
- The Millennial Reign of Christ and His Glorified Saints
- The Final Judgment and New Creation

It all begins with this recovered phrase: *The Day of the Lord*.

That Day should not be a moment of fear, but a season of victory. Not an escape, but an enthronement. Not the end, but *the long-awaited beginning of the reign of God on earth*.

“The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever.”

— Revelation 11:15



Addendum: Glorified Saints vs. Angelic Hosts

1. Glorified Saints = The New Divine Council / Executive Cabinet

- **Daniel 7:27** — *“And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High...”*
- **Revelation 5:10** — *“...and they shall reign on the earth.”*
- **1 Corinthians 6:2-3** — *“Do you not know that the saints will judge the world? ... Do you not know that we are to judge angels?”*

This governance role is consistent with the Divine Council paradigm (Heiser et al.), in which glorified humans replace the disloyal *elohim*. Psalm 82 foreshadows this turnover:

82 [6] *“I said, ‘You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you; [7] nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince.”*

— **Psalm 82:6-7**

Jesus quotes this Psalm in **John 10:34-36**, affirming that these “sons of God” were once divine beings. Their judgment is certain. They are stripped of their immortality, cast down, and replaced by the glorified saints.

2. Glorified Saints Never Engage in Warfare

There is no biblical passage that depicts glorified, resurrected saints engaging in battle. Throughout Scripture, it is always the *angelic hosts* who do the fighting.

The glorified saints serve in civil government, judicial roles, and kingdom administration during the Millennium.

Revelation 19 emphasizes this distinction:

19 [14] “And the armies of heaven, arrayed in fine linen, white and pure, were following Him on white horses. [15] From His mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations, and He will rule them with a rod of iron. He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”

— **Revelation 19:14-15**

3. Christ Alone Treads the Winepress

Only Christ executes the wrath of God:

“He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”

— **Revelation 19:15**

“I have trodden the winepress alone, and from the peoples no one was with me.”

— **Isaiah 63:3**

His singular role underscores His unique authority to execute God’s furious orgé wrath. When Scripture says “from the peoples no one was with me,” it means humans. Humans are people. The glorified saints neither assist nor participate in this judgment. But that doesn’t necessarily mean that angels (“holy ones”) won’t be standing by ready and able to participate.

4. The Armies of Heaven Are Powerful and Fierce Warriors

- **Revelation 19:14** says they are “**the armies of heaven**” — *stratiōtai* in Greek — which unmistakably means **military forces**. There’s no honest way to suggest otherwise.
- Michael and his angels already fought and defeated the

Dragon (**Revelation 12:7-9**). The angelic armies of heaven are **elite, battle-hardened, supernatural warriors**.

- **Zechariah 14:5** refers to them plainly:

“Then the Lord my God will come, and all the holy ones with Him.”

Very important that everyone understands this:

“Holy ones” (Hebrew *qedoshim*, Greek *hagion*)—when used in celestial or eschatological military contexts—**always refers to angelic beings**, i.e., divine council members or loyal *elohim* (as in Deuteronomy 33:2, Daniel 7:10, Zechariah 14:5, etc.). **“Saints”** (*hagios* in plural form in Greek) — consistently refers to **redeemed human believers**, particularly in NT usage and in Pauline writings. **“Holy ones” = angels/elohim. “Saints” = humans.**

Conclusion:

Nowhere in Scripture do we see glorified saints wielding weapons or participating in combat. Their mission will be administrative and judicial — aligned with their role as Christ’s divine cabinet and co-heirs of the Kingdom. Warfare is the domain of Christ and His angelic armies, not of the glorified human “saints.”

(End)

Jesus came. He's coming again!





WHY PRESUPPOSITIONS MATTER

SEEING SCRIPTURE CLEARLY STARTS WITH EXAMINING OUR ASSUMPTIONS

God's Word has always been powerful and pure. Nothing can improve upon what He has spoken. Yet in modern times—especially in the English-speaking West—His Word has been reshaped, repackaged, and rebranded. As D.A. Carson observed, every translation carries interpretive choices, and those choices inevitably shape how the text is received.¹ Too often, voices seeking influence or profit leave their fingerprints on Scripture's translation and teaching.

I am writing this book to draw your attention to a fundamental problem: God is One, and His Church should be One. Yet division marks the modern Christian landscape. Isn't this just like Satan—to divide and conquer?

We all wear lenses when we read the Bible. These lenses are formed by our upbringing, culture, church experiences, and even the joys and pains of life. They shape our worldview, and our worldview, in turn, affects what we perceive to be honest, trustworthy, and accurate.

The Power of Influencers

In today's digital age, the term *influencer* is often applied to celebrities, marketers, and social media personalities who shape how people think, buy, and behave. The same dynamic operates in Bible reading and teaching—though with far greater consequences.

Some of the most powerful influencers in Christianity are not individuals at all but systems and institutions:

- Competing English translations (KJV, NIV, ESV, and many more)
- Denominations that fracture the body of Christ
- Charismatic, polished preachers who entertain more than they edify
- Bestselling authors and films that popularize speculative theology (think *Left Behind*)

Each of these influences reshapes our perception of God's Word. Each introduces subtle distortions that the biblical authors never intended. And over time, those distortions accumulate into something dangerous: presuppositions.

Presuppositions Are Baggage

Drive through almost any town in America, and you'll notice more church brands than fast-food restaurants. You might wonder: How did the body of Christ become so divided? How do so many churches maintain distinct identities while claiming loyalty to the same Bible?

The answer, in part, is presuppositions. Influencers create them, communities reinforce them, and eventually they become the baggage we carry into every reading of Scripture.

As the late Dr. Michael Heiser argued, modern church traditions often filter out the supernatural worldview of the biblical authors. In

doing so, we end up with a different story than the one they were actually telling.²

Think of it this way: take mental filters, worldviews, denominational loyalties, and cultural expectations—toss them into a blender—and what comes out is a thick mixture of presuppositions. These presuppositions:

- Distort God's story.
- Disguise His covenantal love.
- Twist His Word into something unrecognizable.

In short, presuppositions act as baggage—heavy, distorting, and often unnoticed—that we bring with us every time we open the Bible.

Testing Our Lens

Yes, the gospel is about personal salvation. But it is more than that—it is the royal announcement of a coming King and His Kingdom.

But what do we assume about “the heavens”? Do we picture an ethereal escape in the sky, or do we see it as Scripture presents it—a reality that will dwell on earth, as it is in heaven?

Do we assume God needs a “dwelling place,” as if He were limited? Or do we recognize that His intention has always been to dwell with humanity in His created world?

What about Israel and the Church? Do we assume the Church has replaced Israel—a divine detour in God's plan? New Testament scholars like N.T. Wright remind us that the Church was never meant to replace Israel, but to embody the fulfillment of God's covenant promises.³ Or do we see the biblical story of one family of faith, grafted into the promises made to Abraham?

These questions are the product of presuppositions—and they shape everything about how we read and live the Bible.

The Quiet Power of Assumptions

Presuppositions rarely come from careful study. They usually develop long before we know how to test them.

- A child hears a simplified story in Sunday School.
- A preacher passes along a tradition unexamined.
- A study Bible footnote frames how we interpret a passage.

Layer by layer, ideas accumulate. Like grime on a windshield, they slowly cloud our vision. Before long, we may be reading the right words but seeing the wrong story.

Many believers grow up assuming:

- That heaven is our eternal home and earth is just a testing ground.
- That the Church has replaced Israel, as if God discards what He once called holy.
- That Jesus could return at any moment, regardless of the conditions the Bible clearly outlines.

These are presuppositions—and they matter.

Devoted and Righteous... and Still Missing It

You can be faithful, devoted, and hungry for truth, and still miss central themes of Scripture:

- The resurrection of the dead.
- The millennial restoration of all things.
- The physical reign of Christ on earth.

- God's unwavering faithfulness to His covenant people.

Have we been handed a box of puzzle pieces and told to create a picture the Bible never painted? Have we been faithful to the text, yet blind to the story?

That is the danger of presuppositions.

Discipleship Means Letting Go of Baggage

This book is not written out of cynicism or a desire to stir controversy. It is written to ask one central question:

“Have we been believing things Scripture never actually said?”

I've had to ask myself that question, and now I am inviting you to do the same. This is what discipleship requires:

- Taking up our cross.
- Laying down our pride.
- Letting God's Word speak freshly and faithfully, as the biblical authors intended.

But to do that, we must first face our presuppositions. We must identify the baggage we've carried for years—and choose to set it down at the foot of the cross.

These aren't just my opinions. As scholars from Carson to Heiser to Wright have demonstrated, presuppositions are the silent forces shaping how Christians read their Bibles today.

Endnotes

1. D.A. Carson, *The King James Version Debate: A Plea for Realism* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1979).

2. Michael S. Heiser, *The Unseen Realm: Recovering the Supernatural Worldview of the Bible* (Bellingham, WA: Lexham Press, 2015).
3. N.T. Wright, *Paul and the Faithfulness of God* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2013).



REFLECT & Discuss

1. What assumptions or lenses do you bring when reading Scripture?
2. How have translations or teachers influenced your understanding of the Bible?
3. How do your views of heaven, earth, and Israel align with Scripture?
4. Can you identify a belief that might be more tradition than biblical truth?
5. How might letting go of presuppositions clarify your understanding of God's Word?

A BLANK PAGE FOR YOUR NOTES

THE DEVIL'S PSYOPS: COGNITIVE DISSONANCE & CONFIRMATION BIAS

HOW SATAN WEAPONIZES THE MIND TO
RESIST TRUTH AND REFRAME REALITY

In Chapter 1, we explored how presuppositions shape the way we read Scripture. But presuppositions don't form in a vacuum. They are reinforced, weaponized, and defended by an enemy who has been running psychological operations since Eden.

If presuppositions are the baggage we carry, Satan's psyops ensure we never put that baggage down.

The enemy's most effective tactic isn't always direct assault.

"As I urged you when I was going to Macedonia, remain at Ephesus so that you may charge certain persons not to teach any different doctrine, nor to devote themselves to myths and endless genealogies, which promote speculations rather than the stewardship from God that is by faith."

— 1 Timothy 1:3-4

The Apostle Paul warned against speculations—beliefs built on tradition, myth, or imagination—rather than on the secure foundation of Scripture. Speculative ideas don't just lead people away from the truth; they often reinforce confidence in false doctrine.

The enemy works through deception and reinforced self-deception.

That's psychological warfare—a slow, subtle distortion of perception that causes believers to cling to comforting lies rather than confront uncomfortable truths.

Satan's Playbook

A PsyOp is a military term for a psychological operation designed to influence, confuse, or mislead the enemy. Satan has been conducting psychological operations (psyops) ever since the Garden of Eden (**Genesis 3:1**).

"Did God actually say...?"

It wasn't just a question. It was the first cognitive wedge driven between God's Word and the human mind.

Sophisticated Methods

Today, Satan uses more sophisticated methods:

- False theology cloaked in tradition
- Preachers who reaffirm our biases
- Cultural assumptions that reinforce biblical errors

Two of Satan's sharpest tools are what psychologists call *Cognitive Dissonance* and *Confirmation Bias*.

Cognitive Dissonance

Cognitive Dissonance is the internal tension that arises when new information contradicts something we already believe. The discomfort can be so significant that we instinctively reject the latest information—even if it is true—to protect our emotional equilibrium.

Peter didn't calmly take notes when Jesus predicted His suffering and death. He rebuked Jesus:

"Far be it from you, Lord! This shall never happen to you!"

— **Matthew 16:22**

Peter's framework couldn't accept the thought of a suffering Messiah, so he rejected the truth to preserve his preconceived expectation. That is cognitive dissonance in action.

Confirmation Bias

Confirmation Bias is the tendency to seek evidence that supports what we already believe while ignoring or dismissing challenges. It is the invisible hand guiding:

- Which sermons we listen to
- Which teachers we trust
- Which verses we underline
- Which we quietly skip

The Feedback Loop

Cognitive Dissonance and Confirmation Bias create a powerful feedback loop:

- First, we feel threatened by truth (cognitive dissonance).
- Then, we cling even harder to what is comfortable but untrue (confirmation bias).

This loop is Satan's psyop in full swing.

Why Correction Error Often Fails

This feedback loop explains why some believers double down on

false ideas even after being shown precise biblical correction. Their worldview cannot admit the truth without everything else falling apart. Instead of confronting a deflated ego, they retreat further into what they are so heavily invested in.

We've seen it before:

- Sermons that ignore dozens of Scriptures in favor of the theological framework of a denomination or an influential church board member.
- Charts and graphs of timelines that skip God's promises to Israel.
- Endless hype about "the rapture" for escape rather than conceding to the truth about Christ's parousia and the restoration of the earth.

Spiritual Whiplash

Cognitive dissonance can create a kind of spiritual whiplash. Believers sense that something is off—but rather than allowing the tension to lead them toward truth, they suppress *even the thought* that they could be wrong.

It is the *embarrassment* of realizing that a long-held investment in a belief may be flawed. As Jack Nicholson's character told Tom Cruise in *A Few Good Men*: "Son, *you can't handle the truth!*"

Deception hardens the heart—not in rebellion, but in a refusal to admit error.

Be a Berean — Your Road to Recovery

How do we become Bereans in a world full of filters and presuppositions?

“The brothers immediately sent Paul and Silas away by night to Berea, and when they arrived, they went into the Jewish synagogue. Now these Jews were more noble than those in Thessalonica; they received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so.”

— Acts 17:10-11

Family, pastors, denominations, books, and traditions may pass down ideas that do not align with Scripture. Spiritual maturity requires *discernment*: we must test what we’ve been taught—out of reverence for God’s truth. Don’t allow yourself to settle for excuses like, *“It’s what I was taught and I’m too set in my ways to change.”*

Being a Berean means:

- Allowing yourself the opportunity to be proven right or wrong by Scripture, favoring the original language and context.
- Taking responsibility for your understanding or misunderstanding.
- Verifying God’s Word directly for yourself, without relying on commentaries or charts.

It takes Courage and Strength of Faith

That is the heart of this chapter and this series. We do not tear down truth—we tear down the filters and presuppositions that obscure it.

You don’t need to be a professional scholar. You must, however, be willing to slow down, question assumptions, and let Scripture reframe your vision. Seek what God said. Admit when translation errors have crept in.

True discipleship requires recalibration, and the Word of God deserves to be proclaimed with clarity and precision.

Endnotes

1 Timothy 1:3-4: Paul urged correction of those who teach false doctrines, which promote speculation rather than faith.

Genesis 3:1: The serpent subtly introduced doubt—the first distortion of divine instruction.

Matthew 16:22: Peter rebuked Jesus, illustrating human resistance to God's plan.

Acts 17:10-11: The Berean model faithfully discerns by examining Scripture daily.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. What are (a) Cognitive Dissonance and (b) Confirmation Bias?
2. Without naming names, do you know someone experiencing either?
3. If you discovered a Bible truth that differed from your community's theology, how would you respond?
4. How does the enemy exploit fear in professing believers?

A BLANK PAGE FOR YOUR NOTES

UNDERSTANDING COVENANTS — A BIBLICAL FRAMEWORK

TRACING GOD’S UNBREAKABLE PROMISES
FROM EDEN TO THE END OF THE AGE

God’s relationship with humanity is built on something tangible: covenants. Covenants are promises. In modern legalese, this is akin to contract law. From the Garden of Eden to Mount Sinai, from Abraham to Israel, from the Tabernacle to the Cross, God made His intentions known through a series of relational commitments—*covenants*.

Unilateral vs. Bilateral Covenants

A **unilateral covenant** is a single-party pledge: only one side makes a promise, like a Last Will & Testament: “*I hereby bequeath...*” Only the promisor is bound.

A **bilateral covenant** involves two parties committing to specific obligations and conditions. Its hallmark is reciprocity: “*If you remain faithful, then I guarantee your salvation.*” Salvation is a gift, but its benefits are realized through faithful obedience.

God can never renege on His covenant promises—but humanity can,

through free will. Misunderstanding covenantal principles distorts the story of redemption.

The Gospel: One Complex Covenant

The Gospel reflects God's progressive revelation and covenantal continuity. Every doctrine, prophecy, and redemptive act hangs on the covenants God has made. The Gospel is unified yet multifaceted, requiring discernment to see how all the pieces fit.

It spans both Old and New Testaments. God's covenantal promises involve layers: Abraham, Israel, the Davidic line, the Church, the resurrection, and the coming Kingdom. The Bible tells one continuous story: God creating, calling, redeeming, and restoring a people for Himself. Covenant is the spine of Scripture. Without it, the gospel fractures, and the Church drifts.

"For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days," declares the Lord: "I will put my law within them and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people."

— **Jeremiah 31:33**

This chapter recovers the biblical framework of covenant—what it is, how it unfolds, and why it matters for theology, life, hope, and interpretation.

The Edenic Covenant – God's Original Design

The first covenant wasn't written on tablets or sealed with blood; it was spoken. Its condition was simple: Adam and Eve could eat from every tree except the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. Obedience meant life; disobedience meant death. Covenant language is evident:

- Purposeful relationship
- Responsibility
- Promise, and
- Consequence.

God created Adam and Eve in His image, gave them dominion over creation, and commissioned them to be fruitful, multiply, and steward the world. The Garden of Eden was a temple, where heaven and earth met, and Adam and Eve were both image-bearers and priests.

“And the Lord God commanded the man, saying, “You may surely eat of every tree of the garden, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die.”

— **Genesis 2:16-17**

The Fall

Genesis 3 is a covenantal violation—a betrayal of relationship. Yet even in judgment, God’s redemptive plan was already in motion. Evil would not win.

The first prophetic whisper of redemption emerges:

“I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; He shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise His heel.”

— **Genesis 3:15**

A human descendant of the woman would ultimately crush the serpent’s head, though bruised in the process. The Edenic Covenant promised restoration—not by discarding humanity, but by saving it.

Jesus’ death on the Cross fulfilled the Edenic Covenant and established the New Covenant. Through His sacrifice, believers are freed

from the penalty of sin and restored to a relationship with God. He is the mediator, the bridge between humanity and the Creator.

Moving Forward: The Noahic, Mosaic, and Davidic Covenants

God's promises unfold through successive covenants:

- **Noahic Covenant:** Preserving creation and life.
- **Mosaic Covenant:** Establishing law, worship, and holy community.
- **Davidic Covenant:** Promising a messianic King and an eternal kingdom.

Each covenant is a step in God's unbroken plan of redemption and restoration, showing that His Word and promises are unwavering.

The Noahic Covenant – God's Mercy Through Judgment

By Genesis 6, the world was saturated with violence, chaos, and corruption. Humanity, created to reflect God's image, had collapsed into anarchy. Yet even in judgment, God chose mercy—a remnant.

Noah was chosen—not because he was perfect, but because he “found favor in the eyes of the Lord” (Genesis 6:8). Through Noah, God reaffirmed:

Through Noah, God reaffirmed:

- To preserve life,
- To judge evil, and
- To renew the earth.

The covenant was about **a sign** — the rainbow. *Never again by flood!*

“I establish my covenant with you, that never again shall all flesh be cut off

by the waters of the flood... I have set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the covenant between me and the earth.”

— **Genesis 9:11-13**

The Noahic covenant reveals God’s heart in preserving, not destroying. It affirms His sovereignty and maintains His plan of **redemption**.

The Abrahamic Covenant – God's Family and Promise

Abram was a descendant of Noah through Shem. He was a sojourner from Ur in the Chaldeans (**Genesis 11:31**). God called Abram to form a people and promised:

“And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you and make your name great so that you will be a blessing... and in you, all the families of the earth shall be blessed.”

— **Genesis 12:2-3**

The Abrahamic covenant is rooted in faith. Abram believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness (**Genesis 15:6**). This established the pattern of **righteousness through faith, not law**.

God’s covenant with Abraham unfolds in stages: **Genesis 12, 15, 17, and 22**. Each stage magnifies the promise:

- A land
- A blessing (Messiah)
- A sign (circumcision)

Circumcision established **identity**—those in Christ, Jew or Gentile, are “grafted in” to Abraham’s promise. The Abrahamic covenant was never canceled or replaced.

“Know then that it is those of faith who are the sons of Abraham.”
— Galatians 3:7

Covenantal Belonging

In the matter of the Abrahamic Covenant, it was about *God’s determination to build a family, not by bloodline alone*, but by **covenantal belonging**.

Those who are **in Christ**—*Jews and Gentiles alike* — are “grafted into” the covenantal promise God made to Abraham.

Paul affirms that the law never nullified the promise, nor was it ever exclusive to Israel. (**Romans 11:17-24**)

The Abrahamic covenant is still in effect. It was not canceled, redefined, or replaced.

The Mosaic Covenant – A Nation Set Apart

The Abrahamic covenant established a people; the Mosaic covenant organized them into a nation. At Mount Sinai, God betrothed Himself to Israel, and they accepted—though fear and idolatry quickly followed.

God formalized His relationship through law, priesthood, calendar, and worship systems. The Mosaic covenant did **not replace** Abraham’s covenant—it built upon it, giving Israel its constitution as a holy nation:

“Therefore, if you will indeed obey my voice and keep my covenant, (then) you shall be my treasured possession among all peoples...”
— Exodus 19:5

The covenant was conditional—blessing or curse depended on

obedience—and sealed with blood (Exodus 24:8), symbolizing seriousness and the means of restoration. It revealed humanity's need for grace, pointed to a greater priesthood, and foreshadowed Christ, who would write the law on hearts.

“For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, declares the LORD: I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people.”

— **Jeremiah 31:33** (c. 600 BC)

The law was never meant to be a cold legal code; it was a pathway to dwelling with God. At its heart were worship, mercy, and a way of life that reflected God's holiness.

“So then, the law was our guardian until Christ came, so that we might be justified by faith. But now that faith has come, we are no longer under a guardian, for in Christ Jesus you are all sons of God, through faith. For as many of you as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ. There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus. And if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise.”

— **Galatians 3:24-29**

Sinai was preparation for Zion.

The Davidic Covenant – God's Eternal Throne

God narrowed His promise further—from a people to a king, and from a king to a dynasty:

“When your days are fulfilled, and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you... And I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever.”

— **2 Samuel 7:12-13**

Though Solomon fulfilled aspects near-term, ultimate fulfillment comes through Christ—the eternal King, the Messiah. The Davidic Covenant established: **A house** (dynasty) from David's line

- Kingship,
- Permanence, and
- A royal Son who would rule forever.

The Psalms, prophets, and Gospels continually echo this hope (**Psalm 89:29; Isaiah 9:6-7; Matthew 1:1**). The principle of **already-but-not-yet** reminds us that Christ has inaugurated the kingdom but will fully establish it on earth in the future.

The New Covenant – From Fulfillment to Forever

The New Covenant fulfills all previous covenants: Edenic, Noahic, Abrahamic, Mosaic, and Davidic. Jeremiah foretold it:

“Behold, the days are coming,” declares the Lord, “when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah...”

— **Jeremiah 31:31** (c. 600 BC)

It transforms hearts, emphasizing love over law, forgiveness over sacrifice. Jesus inaugurated it at the Last Supper:

“This cup poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood.”

— **Luke 22:20**

Through His death and resurrection, Christ fulfilled the law's righteous requirement, extending salvation to all by faith. He mediates a **better covenant on better promises** (Hebrews 8:6).

The New Covenant fulfilled:

- Forgiveness of sin

- Indwelling of the Holy Spirit
- Access to the Father
- Hope of resurrection
- Promise of a coming kingdom on earth

All covenants converge in Christ, who fulfills and unifies them into one complex Gospel covenant.

Adam – Covenant of Life

↓ (failure → death enters)

Noah – Covenant of Preservation

↓ (creation preserved for redemption)

Abraham – Covenant of Promise

↓ (land, seed, blessing → faith counted as righteous)

Moses – Covenant of Law

↓ (reveals sin, points to need for Messiah)

David – Covenant of Kingship

↓ (promise of eternal throne in David's line)

New Covenant in Christ

↓ (forgiveness, Spirit, eternal life)

Kingdom Consummation – The Day of the Lord



REFLECT & Discuss

1. Which covenant most reshapes your understanding of God's redemptive plan, and why?
2. How does the Mosaic covenant point to the New Covenant and Christ's fulfillment?
3. What does God's covenantal faithfulness teach you about Israel and the Church?
4. How does the New Covenant fulfill, rather than replace, the previous covenants, and what does that mean for the coming Kingdom?

REREADING GENESIS 1:1 — EARTH AND SKY, NOT HEAVEN

RECOVERING WHAT THE BIBLE ACTUALLY
SAYS ABOUT CREATION'S OPENING LINE

Most believers can quote Genesis 1:1 by heart. It's the opening line of the Bible, a verse so familiar it often goes unquestioned:

"In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth."

— **Genesis 1:1**

The Bible's opening verse is familiar to nearly every reader of Scripture, yet its interpretation is often clouded by presuppositions imported from later theological developments or modern cosmology.

In this context, many instinctively equate "the heavens" with the divine dwelling place — "Heaven," their perceived abode of God. However, a careful examination of the Hebrew terms and narrative context reveals a different meaning.

In Hebrew, the phrase used in Genesis 1:1 is בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הָאָרֶץ — "הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ" — "In the beginning, God created the shamayim and the aretz," which Hebrew scholars equate to "the heavens and the earth."

The word *shamayim* (שָׁמַיִם, Strong's H8064) is a plural noun, correctly translated as “the heavens,” and used throughout the Hebrew Bible to refer to the sky, atmosphere, and celestial expanse—not the transcendent realm of God's throne.

In the context of the ancient Hebrew worldview, the *shamayim* (שָׁמַיִם) refers to **the sky** — the atmosphere, the space where clouds move and stars twinkle.

Back then, their perspective traveled as far as their eyes could see. The earth was flat, like a cake platter, and the sky was under its preserving dome.

The *shamayim* is the visible canopy overhead, the vault of the sky where thunder rolls and promises echo.

The interpretive key is:

*“And God called the expanse *shamayim*.”*

— **Genesis 1:8**

The semantic domain of *shamayim* includes:

- **The sky and atmosphere** (Genesis 1:20: “birds fly above the face of the expanse of the *shamayim*”),
- **The celestial sphere** (Psalm 19:1: “The *shamayim* declare the glory of God”),
- And on rare occasions, **the spiritual realm**—only when indicated by context (e.g., Psalm 11:4: “The Lord's throne is in heaven”).

This ties *shamayim* to the *raqia'* (רָקִיעַ)—a structured dome separating waters above from waters below.

It's not an ethereal realm of the afterlife, but the sky He painted — material and observable.

Ha-shamayim (“the sky,” “the heavens”) and ha-aretz (“the earth”) appear as *merisms*.

*NOTE: A merism is a literary device that joins two extremes to express a complete whole. In Genesis 1:1, “the heavens and the earth” doesn’t just mean sky and dirt — it means everything, the totality of the created order. It’s like saying “day and night” to mean **all** the time, or “from head to toe” to mean **the whole** body. That’s the power of merism: two extremes to convey a whole.*

The heavens and the earth means the land He formed and the sky He painted—both waiting for their King.

This interpretation harmonizes with the biblical narrative. God’s desire has always been to dwell among His people:

“Then I will dwell among the Israelites...”

— **Exodus 29:45**

“Behold, the tabernacle of God is among men...”

— **Revelation 21:3**

Genesis 1 is **NOT** about escape. It’s about a **RETURN**. It sets the stage for divine fellowship — where heaven meets earth, and *love* begins.

The phrase “*the heavens and the earth*” signals restoration, not removal (Isaiah 65:17; Revelation 21:1).



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **“The Sky” or “Heaven?”** How does reading *shamayim* as the sky — not God’s throne — change how you see Genesis 1:1?
2. **What presuppositions divide the Church?** Where have you seen theology read backward into Scripture and lead to Bible untruths?
3. **Where will be the final destination of the righteous man?**
4. **Where will be the final destination of the unrighteous man?**

GOD'S DESIRE TO DWELL AMONG US — FROM EDEN TO NEW JERUSALEM

THE THREAD OF DIVINE PRESENCE RUNNING
THROUGH THE ENTIRE REDEMPTION STORY

God never intended to stay distant. From the beginning, the Creator's desire was not simply to form a world but *to share it*. He made a garden not just for beauty but for communion. He formed a human *to bear His image* and to walk with Him in the cool of the day.

Eden was not simply paradise — it was God's first dwelling place with humanity.

The narrative of Scripture is not about humanity reaching up to God. It's about God coming down to dwell with us.

This divine desire—to dwell among His people—frames the biblical story:

Eden was the first sanctuary.

The Tabernacle, and later the temple, were designed as micro-Edens, filled with creation imagery and guarded by cherubim.

The incarnation of Jesus was the ultimate descent:

“The Word became flesh and dwelt among us”

— **John 1:14**

And at the end of the greatest of all love stories, the righteous will hear a familiar voice:

“Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them; they will be his people, and God will be with them as their God.”

— **Revelation 21:3**

From Eden to the Tabernacle, from the Tabernacle to the Cross, and from the Cross to the New Jerusalem, the direction has always been the same: God moving **toward us**.

Eden: God's First Sanctuary

Eden was not merely a garden. It was the first sanctuary — the original sacred space — where heaven and earth touched. Eden was the mountain of God, and the garden was on its slope. The imagery is unmistakable: a place filled with life, beauty, order, and the presence of God Himself.

There was no temple building because God is the temple, and Adam and Eve were its first priests.

“And they heard the sound of the Lord God walking in the garden in the cool of the day...”

— **Genesis 3:8**

That phrase—*“walking in the garden”*—evokes the same presence later seen in the tabernacle and temple, where God would *“walk among”* His people (**Leviticus 26:12**).

Eden set the precedent: God intended to dwell with humanity, not apart from us but *among* us. But then, Eden's pristine dwelling place was disrupted—but not abandoned.

God didn't give up. He began the long road of restoring access to His presence. Compare that "as it was in the beginning" situation to how it will forever be:

21 [6] *"It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end."* ... [22] *"And I saw no temple in the city (the New Jerusalem), for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb."*

— Revelation 21:6, 22

The Tabernacle and the Temple: Eden Remembered

At Sinai, when God instructed Moses to build the Tabernacle, the design was filled with Edenic imagery, featuring gold, cherubim, pomegranates, almond blossoms, and a menorah that resembled the Tree of Life. The Tabernacle was **a mobile Eden**—a sacred space where God could again "dwell in the midst" of His people.

Later, Solomon's temple carried the same themes: carved palm trees, flowing water imagery, and a structure oriented to the east, just like Eden.

The high priest's entrance into the Most Holy Place was a symbolic return to the Garden, passing the cherubim that guarded the way.

Even these sacred echoes could only whisper of what was to come: God Himself dwelling among us. But the tabernacle and the temple were merely *temporary* shadows—signposts pointing to a greater future reality — New Jerusalem.

The Incarnation: God Dwells in Flesh

When Jesus was born in Bethlehem, He didn't just represent God — He *was* God. Jesus didn't come to pull us into a higher spiritual plane. **He came to dwell with us** in a world broken by sin.

He came to walk among His suffering creation, with its dust and tears. He breathed our air, and He bore our shame.

“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory as the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.”

— John 1:14

The Greek word for “dwelt” is ἐσκήνωσεν (eskēnōsen) — meaning, **“He tabernacled among us.”** In Christ, the presence of God once again moved toward us. The divine glory that once rested in Eden, then in the Tabernacle and the Temple, and then as Jesus in human flesh — He took up residence amongst us here on the earth.

Jesus Among Us — Where the heavens and the earth Touched

Jesus is where heaven and earth meet — the walking, breathing fulfillment of God's ancient desire to dwell among His people.

When Jesus died, and the veil in the temple was torn in two (**Matthew 27:51**) — the physical barrier between God and humanity was ripped wide open.

And then, as the Firstfruit of resurrection, He foreshadowed our pathway back to restored fellowship with God Himself.

Jesus' Reward Was Received Upon His Ascension

As we see in Acts 1 and Daniel 7, **Jesus' ascension** was when He received His reward.

7 [13]...and He came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before Him.

[14] And to Him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve Him..."

—Daniel 7:13-14

But before He can take possession of His kingdom, He will have to wait until the Day of the Lord.

New Jerusalem — Eden Restored

The Bible doesn't end with souls flying up to heaven. Jesus taught several times (John 3:13, 8:23, 13:33) that humans **never** to go up to heaven. Instead, "heaven" will descend to **earth**.

The final vision in Revelation is not of escape, but of *arrival* — a city descending, a garden renewed, and **God making His permanent home among His people**.

"Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, ... and the sea is no longer..."

— Revelation 21:1

NOTE: In context, to the ancients, "*the sea*" was a metaphor for chaos. Leviathan lives in the sea. When Christ returns, He will rid the world of all chaos and make it "as new" — as Eden was, it shall once again be. There will be streams and rivers to water the plants, as well as lakes and oceans.

"And I saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God..."

— Revelation 21:2

"And I heard a great voice from the throne saying, 'Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.'"

— Revelation 21:3

"And I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty

and the Lamb. And the city does not need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light, and its lamp is the Lamb.”

— **Revelation 21:22-23**

“...through the middle of the street of the city; on either side of the river, the tree of life...”

— **Revelation 22:2**

“And behold, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy in this book.”

— **Revelation 22:7**

New Jerusalem will be Holy Ground

The pattern never changes from Genesis to Revelation. **God’s plan has always been to dwell with His people on the earth He made.** First in a garden, then in a tent, then in flesh — and finally, for eternity, in the new Jerusalem.

Earth is where the Kingdom of God is located. And forevermore, His divine presence will fill all in all.

From the beginning, God’s heart has been to dwell with His people — to walk with them, talk with them, and to be known by them. Eden was just the beginning.

When Jesus arrives on the Day of the Lord, we, His righteous heirs, recently resurrected and then in immortal, glorified bodies, will be His judges and government of the Kingdom of God on the earth.

“Behold, a king will reign in righteousness, and princes will rule in justice.”

— **Isaiah 32:1**



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **From Eden to New Jerusalem, God’s plan has always been to dwell among His people.** How does this challenge popular views of “heaven” as a distant escape, and how might it reshape how we think about our future hope?
2. **How do the Tabernacle and Temple serve as echoes of Eden?** What insights do their design and function give us about God’s character and desire to be near?
3. **Revelation 21 reveals a “return” not to the garden, but to a city—a new Jerusalem.** What does it say about God’s redemptive trajectory for the physical world?

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ISRAEL VS. THE GENTILE CHURCH

WHY GOD'S COVENANT WITH ISRAEL STILL STANDS — AND ALWAYS WILL

For centuries, Christian theology has often carried a silent assumption: that when Israel rejected Jesus, God rejected Israel — and replaced her with the Church.

This belief, often called Supersessionism or Replacement Theology, teaches that the Church has inherited all of Israel's promises while Israel has been left behind.

But this is **not** what the Bible teaches.

God's covenants are irrevocable promises. God does not abandon His promises.

Some assume the Church replaced Israel — but Scripture says otherwise.

The Church is a grafted-in community (**Romans 11**), joined to Israel's promises through the Messiah.

Gentile believers don't become "spiritual Israel." Through Christ, they are joined to the commonwealth of Israel — adopted into a family whose roots stretch back to Abraham.

"...remember that you were... separated from Christ, alienated from the commonwealth of Israel and strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in the world. But now in Christ Jesus, you...have been brought near by the blood of Christ."

— **Ephesians 2:12-13**

Paul could not have been more precise...

The truth? The Church is not a replacement for Israel. It is a grafted-in community.

Paul knew the temptation for Gentile believers to become arrogant, especially as more Jews rejected the gospel. So he offered a warning wrapped in a vivid image — the olive tree:

"But if some of the branches were broken off, and you, although a wild olive shoot, were grafted in among the others and now share in the nourishing root of the olive tree, do not be arrogant toward the branches. If you are, remember it is not you who support the root, but the root that supports you."

— **Romans 11:17-18**

Gentile believers are not a new tree. They're wild branches, grafted into the cultivated Olive Tree — Israel.

Olive Tree Glossary

- **Tree** — Israel, the covenant people
- **Root** — God, the Covenant Maker
- **Grafted branches** — Gentile believers, and when Christ returns, all Israel will be grafted back in ("The Mystery of God.")

The tree still stands. The Root still nourishes. And every promise still holds.

But the nourishing Root of that tree is not Israel. It is God Himself, the Covenant Maker — The One who sustains all His People, Jew and Gentile alike. It was God Himself who fulfilled His New Covenant — through His Son, Jesus the Messiah.

Gentiles now share God's promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Like the Israelites, born-again Gentiles are rooted in God's nourishing covenant. It is because of God's mercy — not because the original branches were discarded.

And Paul drives the point home:

“For if you were cut from what is by nature a wild olive tree, and grafted, contrary to nature, into a cultivated olive tree, how much more will these, the natural branches, be grafted back into their own olive tree?”

— **Romans 11:24**

This is not a replacement — it's a restoration. In the meantime, God had mercy on the faithful Gentiles. The tree is still Israel, and the Messiah remains Israel's King. And the kingdom remains here, on the earth. “Replacement Theology” is a hoax.

The promises belong to the root, and God intends to restore national Israel. This is what is known as, “the Mystery of God.”

God has not abandoned the tree — He plans to bring it back to full fruitfulness.

God's Covenant with Israel Still Stands

Paul wasn't starting a new idea — he was confirming an ancient truth.

He echoes the prophets, who clarified that God's covenant with Israel, despite their rebellion, was unbreakable.

“If this fixed order departs from before me,” declares the Lord, “then shall the offspring of Israel cease from being a nation before me forever.”

— **Jeremiah 31:36**

“If the heavens above can be measured, and the foundations of the earth below can be explored, then I will cast off all the offspring of Israel for all that they have done,” declares the Lord.

— **Jeremiah 31:37**

In other words, **Never!**

Israel’s story isn’t over — it’s entering its most redemptive chapter.

The prophets foresaw survival, national cleansing, renewal, and return.

God links His faithfulness to Israel with the stability of the created order.

As long as the stars still shine, Israel still stands.

The Promise of Restoration — Israel to be “Baptized”

The prophets didn’t just affirm God’s commitment — they foretold Israel’s future repentance and restoration.

“I will take you from the nations and gather you from all the countries and bring you to your own land. I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleannesses, and from all your idols I will cleanse you.”

— **Ezekiel 36:24-25**

Ezekiel 36:25 is prophesying: Christ will “baptize” the Messianic remnant on the Day of the Lord. This is what is meant by “**the Mystery of God.**”

*“And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you...
...and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules. You shall dwell in the land I gave to your fathers, and you shall be my people, and I will be your God.”*
— **Ezekiel 36:26-28**

Israel in Revelation: Not Replaced, but Sealed

Even at the end of the age, when visions reach their most cosmic proportions, Israel remains distinct in God's plan.

“And I heard the number of the sealed, 144,000, sealed from every tribe of the sons of Israel...”
— **Revelation 7:4**

These twelve tribes are *not* symbolic stand-ins for the Church. They're literal, ethnic descendants of Jacob — **a faithful remnant set apart during the tribulation.**

Revelation 7 is a powerful one-two punch: *The 144,000 of Israel are sealed* (vv. 1–8). *Then, a great multitude from every nation appears* (vv. 9–10) — not instead of Israel, but *alongside* of Israel.

New Jerusalem and the Twelve Tribes

Even in the eternal state, God will preserve Israel's identity:

“It had a great, high wall, with twelve gates, and at the gates twelve angels, and on the gates, the names of the twelve tribes of the sons of Israel were inscribed.”
— **Revelation 21:12**

Israel's history will not be erased in the New Creation. **It is engraved on the gates of the city of God!** This is an honor!

And on the city's foundations, as well...

“And the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them were the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.”

— **Revelation 21:14**

Twelve tribes. Twelve apostles.

Israel and the Church — distinct but united, woven into the very architecture of eternity.

One Family — One Messiah — One Kingdom

God never intended to replace Israel — only to include the Gentile nations.

It was never God's plan to replace Israel with “the Church.”

From the beginning, the promise was:

Through Israel, “all the families of the earth shall be blessed.”

— **Genesis 12:3**

The Church is not Plan B. It is the ingathering of the nations, joined to the covenant family through the Messiah.



Reflect & Discuss

1. **What assumptions have you previously held about Israel and the Church?** How does the imagery of the olive tree in Romans 11 challenge or confirm those assumptions?
2. **Why is it important to understand that Gentile believers are grafted in — not *replacements*?** How does this shape our view of God's covenant faithfulness?
3. **How does recognizing Israel's ongoing role in God's redemptive plan affect your reading of prophecy and God's future promises?** In what ways does it deepen your understanding of the "bigger story" of Scripture?

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LANGUAGE MATTERS — SHAMAYIM, SHEOL, GEHENNA, PARADISE

HOW THE BIBLE'S ORIGINAL WORDS CLARIFY
THE AFTERLIFE AND JUDGMENT

Words shape our theology. When we misunderstand Scripture's vocabulary, we don't just lose nuance — we risk building doctrines on fragile foundations.

Too often, English translations obscure the original meanings of key biblical terms, particularly those related to death, the afterlife, and final judgment.

Words like “heaven,” “hell,” and “paradise” are commonly used, but not always accurately translated.

This chapter aims to clarify these crucial biblical words, returning to their original usage and meaning.

Shamayim (שָׁמַיִם)

- **Meaning:** “The heavens” — the sky, the atmosphere that surrounds our planet. In the beginning, God created the heavens, not Heaven.
- **Reference:** Genesis 1:1

- **Notes:** A material, visible realm — not a spiritual afterlife, i.e., not Heaven.

In Genesis 1:1, *shamayim* refers to the visible sky — the place of clouds, birds, and stars. It does not mean “Heaven” as God’s throne room. *Shamayim* is paired with *aretz* (earth). In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth — a single bundled package.

Sheol (שְׁאוֹל)

- **Meaning:** Realm of the dead (both righteous and unrighteous)
- **References:** Psalm 16:10; Genesis 37:35; Luke 16:22-26
- **Notes:** Divided into two compartments: *Paradise* (comfort) and *Hades* (torment). Temporary.

Sheol is a real, spiritual realm—a temporary abode within the inner earth for the dead awaiting resurrection. Early Scripture mentions *Sheol* ambiguously, but Jesus (Luke 16) revealed its two divisions:

- **Paradise:** A place of comfort for the righteous.
- **Hades:** A place of anguish for the unrighteous.

Luke 16 presents *Sheol*: Abraham and the righteous are at peace, while the wicked are in anguish. And between them is a chasm.

Calling *Sheol*’s *Hades* “hell” was the Old Testament’s way of acknowledging death without finality — a confusion that unfortunately led to yet another imagination: Purgatory.

No reincarnation. No purgatory. No limbo. Only righteous or unrighteous.

There is no reincarnation, purgatory, or limbo. Hebrews 9:27 states: “It is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.”

Upon death, each person is immediately judged. Angels escort the disembodied soul/spirit of the righteous to Paradise. The spirit of the unrighteous is escorted to Hades.

Bearing the Seal of God

Entry into Paradise is like being “cleared through customs”—bearing the Lord’s mark on your forehead.

- **Revelation 7:3** — *“Until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads.”*
- **Revelation 14:1** — *“The Lamb...with Him 144,000 who had His name and His Father’s name on their foreheads.”*
- **Revelation 22:4** — *“They will see His face, and His name will be on their foreheads.”*

Those sealed by God are protected and marked as **His treasured possessions**.

- **Paradise** evokes Eden’s imagery—a garden where God dwells with His people. Sheol’s Paradise is uniquely distinct from “Heaven” — wherever that is.

Paradise (παράδεισος)

- **Meaning:** Restful abode for the righteous dead
- **References:** **Luke 23:43; Revelation 2:7; Hebrews 12:23**
- **Notes:** Paradise is a temporary, peaceful waiting place.

In Luke 23:43, when Jesus told the repentant thief, *“Today you will be with me in Paradise,”* Jesus was not referring to God’s celestial abode. Instead, Jesus spoke of this very real waiting place — a spirit realm in the earth — a compartment of Sheol.

We can only speculate about activities the occupants of Paradise

might enjoy, but this author envisions these righteous preparing to participate in King Jesus' government and renewal of the earth.

Conditions in Sheol's Paradise

Paradise offers comfort, relational presence, and conscious rest. Scripture gives us limited glimpses of what conscious rest and comfort mean:

Luke 16:22-25: Lazarus is “comforted” (*parakaleitai*—emotional relief and peace).

Revelation 6:9-11: Souls under the altar cry out for justice and are given white robes.

NOTE: “Crying out *for justice*” does not mean “crying out in agony or pain.” Agony or pain are things suffered by the condemned in Sheol's Hades. Righteous martyrs are heroic, victorious overcomers who are enjoying the presence of the Lord in Sheol's Paradise.

NOTE: The Tree of Life was in Eden (**Genesis 2:9**). It is currently located in Paradise (**Revelation 2:7**). And one day, it will be in New Jerusalem (**Revelation 22:2**).

“To the one overcoming, I will give him to eat of the Tree of Life, which is in God's Paradise.”

— **Revelation 2:7b:**

Unpleasant Places for the Unrighteous

Hades (Ἅδης)

- **Meaning:** Torment side of Sheol
- **References:** **Luke 16:23; Revelation 20:13**
- **Notes:** Conscious anguish, awaiting final judgment.

Gehenna (γεέννα)

- **Meaning:** Place of final destruction
- **References:** **Matthew 10:28; Mark 9:47-48; Isaiah 66:24**
- **Notes:** Final. Irreversible judgment. Sometimes associated with the Lake of Fire.

In Hebrew, *Ge-Hinnom* refers to the Valley of Hinnom, a.k.a. the Valley of Slaughter — the valley south of Jerusalem, where children were sacrificed to the Canaanite god Molech. **2 Chronicles 28:3; 33:6; Jeremiah 7:31; 19:2-6.** See also **Leviticus 18:21** and **2 Kings 23:10.** Jesus used Gehenna as an illustration that resembles unceasing torment. Hades or hell are temporary, where unrighteous spirits await the Great White Throne judgment. The lake of fire is eternal.

Tartarus (ταρταρωσ)

- **Meaning:** Prison for rebellious angels
- **Reference:** **2 Peter 2:4**
- **Notes:** Reserved for fallen spiritual beings, not humans.

In Ancient Greek mythology, Tartarus was a terrifying pit of torment reserved for supernatural beings. The Greek *Tartarus* is used only once in Scripture, and is said to be where “angels who sinned” are in chains of darkness while they await the final judgment.

See also: **Genesis 6:2, Luke 8:31, Jude 6, and Revelation 9:5.**

NOTE: Tartarus may be another name for “the Abyss” or “the bottomless pit.” Some English translations imply it is “the deepest abyss of Hades.”

Lake of Fire

- **Meaning:** Final place of disposition after the White Throne for those whose names are not in the book of life.
- **Reference:** **Revelation 19:20; 20:10-15; 21:8**
- **Notes:** Eternal “Second Death” for all the unrighteous.

The lake of fire is referenced as the place of eternal punishment for both angelic and human beings.

Revelation 20:15 says, “...if anyone’s name is not found written in the book of life, he will be thrown into the lake of fire.” See also: **Matthew 25:41**, **Mark 9:43-46**, and **Luke 16:24**.

What happens when a human dies?

Here’s what we know: Once a person dies, the *first* judgment is immediate. As **Hebrews 9:27** states, “*It is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.*”

There is no post-mortem reincarnation, purgatory, limbo, or any other form of second chance. There is no provision to “pray” a disembodied soul-spirit to “redemption” or “salvation.”

NOTE: Angelology: Angels do not have souls. Therefore, they possess no capacity for redemption or salvation. As Psalm 82 portrays, when an angel (elohim) disobeys or displeases God (Elohim), that angel is tried in God’s Divine Council and, in this particular case in Psalm 82, the angel’s sentence was one of demotion — his previously immortal body was degraded to that like a human’s, which will age, die, and decay. Contrast that with the new, glorified, eternal bodies promised to righteous humans. Also, all angels are male. There are no female angels. Angels do not reproduce. If God wants more angels, He creates them.

NOTE: Humanology: Upon death, each disembodied soul-spirit is escorted by angels to either Paradise, the resting place of the right-

eous, or Hades, the place of torment. Sheol is a temporary waiting place. The righteous are awaiting their resurrection and eternity in the presence of the Lord. The unrighteous are waiting for the Great White Throne judgment and eternity in the lake of fire.

Bearing the Seal of God on Foreheads

Entry into Paradise is like being “cleared through customs” — you bear the Lord’s mark, and you wait for your resurrection on the day of the Lord.

“And the Lord said to him, ‘Pass through the city, through Jerusalem, and put a mark on the foreheads of the men who sigh and groan over all the abominations that are committed in it.’”

— **Ezekiel 9:4**

“Do not harm the earth, sea, or trees until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads.”

— **Revelation 7:3**

“...and behold, on Mount Zion stood the Lamb, and with him 144,000 who had his name and his Father’s name written on their foreheads.”

— **Revelation 14:1**

“They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads.”

— **Revelation 22:4**

Conditions and Activities in Paradise

Scripture hints at **comfort and fellowship** in Paradise - but stops short of describing active “enjoyable activities” like feasting, singing, or working.

Here are a few verses that give us vague hints, though...

Of course, **Luke 16:22-25** describes Lazarus in “Abraham’s Bosom”: “(Lazarus) *is comforted here.*” “**Comforted**” (Greek: *parakaleitai*) is the operative word. It strongly suggests *relief, encouragement, and emotional peace* — an enjoyable state compared to the torment of Hades.

NOTE: The Kingdom of Heaven = The Kingdom of God = the kingdom of the earth that Christ was awarded upon His ascension. **Daniel 7:13-14**, “*I saw in the night visions, and behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and He came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before Him. [14] And to Him (Christ) was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve Him; His dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and His kingdom one that shall not be destroyed.*” On the day of the Lord, Christ will take possession of that kingdom.

“He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers, I will grant to eat of the Tree of Life, which is in the Paradise of God.”

— **Revelation 2:7**

(The Fifth Seal) *does* address the martyrs’ souls “under the altar,” as being conscious and waiting:

“When He opened the fifth seal, I saw under the altar the souls of those who had been slain for the word of God and for the witness they had borne. They cried out with a loud voice, ‘O Sovereign Lord, holy and true, how long before you will judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?’ Then they were each given a white robe and told to rest a little longer...”

— **Revelation 6:9-11**

NOTE: There is no indication that these souls “under the altar” are in any distress. As martyrs, they were faithful unto death — and they have been judged righteous. Therefore, the conclusion is that they

are presently in Paradise. There is an altar in Paradise. The tree of life is in Paradise. And there's a lot more, too!

Scripture pictures paradise as a place of conscious comfort and peace, especially in the presence of the patriarchs—a state of profound relational joy and restful anticipation, though not yet the fullness of active post-resurrection life.

Impossible to Pray the Dead to Salvation

Once a human takes his or her final breath, there is no opportunity to accept Jesus' gift of salvation.

In other words, it is **impossible to pray to someone who has died to Salvation.**

Summary

In Luke 16, Jesus presented Sheol as a structured place where disembodied yet conscious spirits await their final destination.

For the righteous, the next destination is eternity in the presence of the Lord. Where Revelation 6:11 says, "*Then they were each given a white robe and told to rest a little longer...*", this *might* mean they were given their glorified, immortal bodies?

For the unrighteous, the next destination beyond Sheol's Hades is the Great White Throne Judgment and the lake of fire.

Traditions and English renderings have led many to associate Sheol solely with dread, but this perspective unfairly equates it with Hades and fear-based imagery. The Bible, however, paints a much richer picture of the two distinct compartments of Sheol.



Reflect & Discuss

1. **How has your understanding of words like “heaven,” “hell,” and “paradise” changed after learning the original biblical terms?** How might this affect how you view death, judgment, and resurrection?
2. **Jesus’ references to Gehenna and Paradise were more than metaphors.** How does understanding their historical and theological roots help clarify His teachings on judgment and hope?
3. **If Sheol’s Hades is temporary and the Lake of Fire is final, what does that say about God’s justice and mercy during the in-between?** How does this affect your view of the Day of the Lord and the resurrection of the righteous?

THE KINGDOM NOW AND NOT YET

EXPOSING THE ERROR OF PRESENT-DAY KINGDOM THEOLOGY AND RESTORING THE PROMISE OF CHRIST'S FUTURE REIGN

John the Baptist preached: *Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand* (Matthew 3:2). Jesus' message: *The kingdom of God is at hand* (Mark 1:15).

Two thousand years later, the world still groans, persecution intensifies, and the nations rage. If the kingdom has come, where is it? This is another example of already, but not yet. The kingdom of God is already here, but not yet fully revealed. It's a present spiritual reality and a future physical fulfillment. Jesus inaugurated it at His first coming and will consummate it at His return, on the Day of the Lord.

This chapter explores the tension of the **now and not yet** — a foundational theme that helps us understand:

- Why did Jesus heal but didn't heal everyone?
- Why does Jesus reign, but the nations have not yet been brought fully under His authority?

The Kingdom On Earth Was Always the Goal

God's redemptive plan has always involved a King and a Kingdom—absolute reign over real people on real land.

The Kingdom did not begin with Jesus' death, resurrection, and ascension; it was promised long before, woven into the very structure of God's covenants.

"I will raise up your offspring after you...and I will establish the throne of His kingdom forever."

— 2 Samuel 7:12-13

This wasn't just about Solomon. It was about a future Son of David (Jesus) who would sit on the throne forever. The prophets saw it, too:

"For to us a child is born... and the government shall be upon his shoulder... Of the increase of his government and peace, there will be no end, on the throne of David and over his kingdom."

— Isaiah 9:6-7

The expectation was clear: a Messiah who would reign in justice, on Zion, forever.

Jesus: The King Has Come

When Jesus arrived the first time, He declared the arrival of the Kingdom:

"I must preach the good news of the kingdom of God... for I was sent for this purpose."

— Luke 4:43

But remember the principle of "already, but not yet." Jesus has yet to ascend His earthly throne. There is no kingdom without a king. The King, Jesus, will arrive on the Day of the Lord. Christ is currently inaugurated, but not yet enthroned on David's throne in Jerusalem.

*"The Lord said to my Lord, 'Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies
your footstool.'"*

— **Psalm 110:1**

This verse is the cornerstone of Christ's present reign, awaiting visible fulfillment.

The kingdom is present in power, working through His Spirit and His Church — but the final stage is still to come.

The Kingdom Yet to Come — The King Returns

The *"not yet"* of the Kingdom is a certainty on the calendar of God — a future moment when **what is now hidden will be fully revealed**.

*"The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and his
Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever."*

— **Revelation 11:15**

This is describing the time when "Heaven" comes to earth — not figuratively, but visibly. Heaven is not a place, it's a concept — wherever God is, it is heavenly. It is more of an adverb than a noun. Since God is omnipresent, He is everywhere all the time. To be in His presence would be heavenly. Therefore, at this moment, God is present in Sheol's Paradise as much as anywhere else.

When Paul said, "I would rather be absent from my body and in the presence of the Lord," Paul did not mean in God's heavenly abode as many have been taught to imagine it. Paul suggested he was looking forward to eternity in the presence of the Lord, wherever that should be. And as an earthbound human — as we all are, that means either in Paradise, or on the surface of the earth. Never "up there in Heaven."

The trumpet sounds, the King descends, and the reign of the Messiah manifests before every nation and every eye.

“And the Lord will be king over all the earth. On that day, the Lord and his name will be one.”

— **Zechariah 14:9**

This is a declaration: The King of Kings will reign on the earth—from Jerusalem’s Mount Zion—over the nations, in righteousness and peace.

It is the fulfillment of every covenant, the realization of every prophecy, the crowning moment of the Gospel itself.

God’s promises do not float aimlessly in the clouds; they are anchored in history, covenant, and flesh.

Every word He spoke through the prophets points to a future not of escape, but of restoration.

NOTE: Whenever you read “on that day,” the subject day is *the Day of the Lord* — *the day of Christ’s parousia*. It is at the start of that Day, as Christ descends, that the righteous dead and alive saints will rise to meet him in the air, arrayed in their new, immortal, glorified bodies. We will be gathered to Him and follow Him back to the earth. Just as was foreshadowed by the Jerusalem crowd on Palm Sunday, only this time, He will be riding a white war horse, instead of a humble donkey.

The Kingdom Is the Destination

The Gospel doesn’t end with “you go to heaven when you die.” For the righteous, death is like a football game’s halftime. And Sheol’s Paradise is the locker room where we change into fresh uniforms.

“You have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they shall reign on the earth.”

— **Revelation 5:10**

Paradise — The Home Team's Locker Room

Halftime is almost over, and the home team is about to return to the field. The first death isn't the end of the game — get your spiritual adrenaline flowing — we're about to start the second half!

The Resurrection Matters

Eternity doesn't happen when we go “up” — it happens when Father God Almighty joins us “down” here!

What's our assignment for the third quarter? To help King Jesus restore the earth and prepare it to receive New Jerusalem!

We were made for this —
to reign with Christ,
We shall reign with Him —
Not in clouds, but in cities,
Not as wanderers, but as sons.

Not in the clouds,
But in cities redeemed,
Gardens restored,
And Nations healed.

The meek will inherit the earth.
The curse will be broken.
And the King will dwell among His people.

“No longer will there be anything accursed... they will see His face, and His name will be on their foreheads.”

— **Revelation 22:3-4**



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **Many believe the Kingdom of God is fully present now.**
Based on Scripture, what aspects of the Kingdom are clearly “not yet”?
2. **Jesus taught that the Kingdom is like leaven hidden in dough — present, but not yet fully visible.** What implications does this have for Christians living today?
3. **Understanding that the King has been inaugurated, but the earth is yet to be made His footstool...**
4. How does this shape your view of politics, suffering, and the mission of the Church?

READING THE PROPHETS AS JESUS DID

RECOVERING THE FORWARD-LOOKING LENS OF BIBLICAL PROPHECY

Most Christians today read the prophets as they do crossword puzzles — confusing, cryptic, or sealed off in a long-past era.

Others, with ulterior motives, cherry-pick isolated verses to prove doctrinal positions while ignoring the flow of the text's witness. Jesus, however, treated the prophets with the respect they deserved.

Jesus read Isaiah, Daniel, Zechariah, and the Psalms as living voices, full of promises still unfolding. The apostles did the same.

The prophets were front-page headlines forecasting the coming Kingdom of God.

“These are my words that I spoke to you while I was still with you, that everything written about me in the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms must be fulfilled.”

— **Luke 24:44**

The Bible Jesus read was the Hebrew Scriptures, and He interpreted them in a covenantal, forward-looking manner.

This chapter will explore:

- Why did Jesus and the apostles take the prophets seriously?
- How Daniel, Isaiah, Zechariah, and others forecast Christ's first coming and His return.
- Why modern readers must recover the future-oriented hope of the prophets — instead of spiritualizing them away.

Jesus and the Prophet Daniel

No Old Testament book shaped Jesus' public teaching more than Daniel.

When Jesus described the events of the end — the abomination of desolation, the coming of the Son of Man — He quoted Daniel directly...

“So when you see the abomination of desolation spoken of by the prophet Daniel, standing in the holy place (let the reader understand)...”

— Matthew 24:15

Jesus expected His disciples to know Daniel's visions — not as allegory, but as prophecy.

The most quoted title Jesus used for Himself — “Son of Man” — is drawn directly from Daniel 7:

“...behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man... to him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom.”

— Daniel 7:13-14

This wasn't randomly coincidental — it was intentional.

Jesus placed Himself in Daniel's vision — the one who would ascend, be presented before the Ancient of Days, and receive an everlasting kingdom.

Daniel didn't just see the King — he saw the Kingdom given to the saints:

“And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High...”

— Daniel 7:27

The Apostles Carried the Same Expectation

Jesus' disciples knew the verse, but not its true meaning.

“Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?”

— Acts 1:6

At first, the disciples' eyes glazed over in an attempt to gain complete understanding. They had just spent 40 days with the risen Jesus, being taught about the kingdom (Acts 1:3). What they failed to grasp wasn't “if,” but “when?” And then...

“...He opened their minds to understand the Scriptures, and said to them, “Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and on the third day rise from the dead, and that repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in His name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem.”

— Luke 24:45

Jesus didn't rebuke their theology. He said:

“It is not for you to know times or seasons that the Father has fixed by His own authority.”

— Acts 1:7

In other words, “yes...but not yet.”

Peter Quoting Joel – Acts 2

At Pentecost, Peter had an “Aha!” moment when he suddenly realized:

“This is what was uttered through the prophet Joel...”

— Acts 2:16

Peter realized that the outpouring of the Spirit was the beginning of what Joel prophesied, not the end.

“And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh... And I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth... before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes.”

— Joel 2:28-31

Peter saw Joel’s words in motion, but not yet entirely fulfilled.

The Spirit had been poured out, but the cosmic signs and the “great and awesome Day of the Lord” are still ahead.

Zechariah – Still Waiting

Zechariah is referenced throughout Revelation — especially in its portrayal of Christ’s return:

“On that day his feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives...”

— Zechariah 14:4

Note: Jesus will “stand” on the Mount of Olives, but on the Day of the Lord, Jesus will *land* in Egypt. (Never heard that one before? Stick around, we have more!)

Jesus came once. He's coming again!

“Behold, the LORD is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt; and the idols of Egypt will tremble at His presence, and the heart of the Egyptians will melt within them.”

— Isaiah 19:1

Summary: The Prophets Are Still Speaking

Jesus came to fulfill the prophets.

Jesus read Isaiah, Daniel, Zechariah, and the Psalms as living words, pointing to His suffering and future return in glory.

The apostles also read the prophets, but they were confused about the kingdom. But then on Pentecost, their eyes were opened and they understood the opening chapter would be a long, prophesied story—a story with chapters yet to be fulfilled.

To recover Jesus' worldview is to recover a high view of prophecy as divine promise.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **Jesus interpreted the prophets not through speculation, but fulfillment.** How might reclaiming this lens help us avoid the fear-mongering sensationalism often surrounding modern eschatology?
2. **The disciples Jesus encountered on the road to Emmaus had Scripture, but lacked understanding.** What does this suggest about the role of Christ-centered *interpretation* when reading the prophets?
3. **How can we cultivate a prophetic reading posture?** A posture that balances the whole story arc from Eden to New Jerusalem?

RECOVERING APOSTOLIC EXPECTATION — WHAT THE EARLY CHURCH BELIEVED

RESTORING THE HOPE OF RESURRECTION,
RETURN, AND KINGDOM

The Early Church's Expectation was: Resurrection, Return,
and Reign

The early Church was not confused.

They understood prophecy— and they had a burning expectation:

- The visible return of Jesus Christ to the earth,
- The resurrection of the dead, and
- The establishment of His Kingdom.

This wasn't a fringe view — it was the beating heart of apostolic teaching.

Key Apostolic Themes

- **Resurrection of the Dead:** First Century Believers expected a literal resurrection at Christ's return. (1 Thessalonians 4:16; 1 Corinthians 15:20-23)

- **Return of Christ (Parousia):** The *visible* appearance of Jesus as a victorious King — not a secret or invisible “rapture” event. (Acts 1:11; Matthew 24:30-31)
- **Restoration of the Kingdom:** They expected Jesus to reign from Jerusalem, fulfilling the promises made to Israel. (Acts 1:6-7; Isaiah 2:2-4)

No Secret Rapture — Only a Visible King

The apostles had no concept of a “rapture escape” before tribulation. Nor did they imagine a heavenly retirement in the clouds.

Their faith was deeply Jewish — rooted in covenant, resurrection, and in God's promises made visible on earth.

“Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?”

— Acts 1:6

Jesus only corrected the timing, not the expectation.

The Hope of Resurrection, Not Evacuation

“For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.”

— 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17

The early believers were preparing for **resurrection through faithfulness**. Titus 2:13, “...waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ,”

Their **blessed hope** was never to escape tribulations. They were looking forward to Christ's return because they understood that “on

that day” they would be resurrected from the dead, or “changed,” and spend the rest of their days in the presence of the Lord — first helping Christ restore the earth, getting it ready to receive New Jerusalem — and then for eternity in New Jerusalem.

They understood their role, as heirs with Christ, would involve their participation in the **restoration, transformation, and government of the earth.**

Acts 3 and the Restoration of All Things

“...that He may send the Christ appointed for you, Jesus, Whom heaven must receive until the time for restoring all the things about which God spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets long ago.”

— **Acts 3:20b-21**

Did you catch that?

“...until the time for restoring all the things...”

Peter wasn’t speaking metaphorically. Peter believed Jesus would return to **restore** — not merely redeem individual souls, but to fulfill **everything** the prophets foretold:

- Israel
- The land
- The Kingdom
- The Earth itself

The Early Fathers and the Kingdom to Come

Papias of Hierapolis (c. AD 60–130) — A disciple of Apostle John and a contemporary of Polycarp, wrote:

“There will be a millennium after the resurrection from the dead

when the personal reign of Christ will be established on this very earth.” — (Fragment 6/DSS)

The early church believed Christ would **personally reign on earth** — not from some far-off, distant “heaven.”

Paul’s Gospel Was Kingdom-Centered

Paul taught:

- A future bodily resurrection
- Christ’s visible return
- The inheritance of the saints
- Reigning with Christ on the earth
- The judgment of the world

"The creation itself will be set free from its bondage to corruption...we wait eagerly for adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies."

— **Romans 8:19-23**

"Then comes the end, when He delivers the kingdom to God the Father...The last enemy to be destroyed is death."

— **1 Corinthians 15:24-26**

Paul’s hope was not escapism. It was resurrection, reign, and the defeat of death itself.

The Early Church Knew the King Would One Day Return

- The Scriptures **promised** it.
- The apostles **preached** it.
- The early Church **believed** it.

The Three Pillars of Apostolic Hope

- **Resurrection**
- **Return**
- **Reign**

Christ's appearing will be visible, cosmic, and undeniable — the King descending in power and glory. The destiny of the righteous — our blessed hope — is not retirement in heaven, but restoration on earth.

Jesus will reign from Zion (Jerusalem, Israel), and the saints will inherit the earth alongside Him.

"Therefore encourage one another with these words."

— **1 Thessalonians 4:18**



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **According to Acts 3:20-21, what is the ultimate goal of Christ's return?** How does this challenge the popular view of heaven as a final, disembodied destination?
2. **What does Peter mean by "the restoration of all things"?** Which things are being restored, and how does this align with the promises made to Israel?
3. **The early Church Fathers believed Christ would reign on earth.** How does restoring the apostolic expectation reshape your view of "the Kingdom on earth"?

REFUTING POPULAR ERRORS — A BIBLICAL CHECKLIST

HOW TO SPOT—AND CORRECT— DANGEROUS ASSUMPTIONS

Let Scripture Speak for Itself

Truth matters. Especially when we realize how easily false assumptions can distort what the Bible truly teaches. In this chapter, we confront some of the most entrenched theological errors that have shaped modern Christian thinking.

We are about to reclaim the biblical clarity that the early Church proclaimed.

It's one thing to build a biblical worldview. It's quite another to clear away the rubble of ideas inherited from pulpits, seminaries, or Christian pop culture.

Each of these errors creates confusion and clouds the real hope of the gospel:

1. Error: Heaven is our final home.

Correction: The Bible teaches resurrection and new creation — not permanent disembodied existence.

"I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God..."

— Revelation 21:2

2. Error: The Church replaced Israel.

Correction: Gentiles are grafted in; Israel's promises remain.

"God has not rejected His people whom He foreknew."

— Romans 11:2a

3. Error: The rapture removes believers before tribulation.

Correction: Believers are gathered to Christ *after* tribulation at His return.

"Immediately after the tribulation... they will gather His elect."

— Matthew 24:29-31

4. Error: Death is natural.

Correction: Death is an enemy to be destroyed.

"The last enemy to be destroyed is death."

— 1 Corinthians 15:26

5. Error: God's kingdom is purely spiritual.

Correction: The kingdom will be visible, physical, and rooted on earth.

"To him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom."

— Daniel 7:13-14

6. Error: Jesus' return will be like His first coming.

Correction: At His return, Jesus will not be riding a humble donkey, but a white charger. He will be a Warrior-King.

“...behold, a white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True, ... He is clothed in a robe dipped in blood,...He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”

— **Revelation 19:11-16**

NOTE: *Thlipsis* is the Greek word that refers to Satan's *temporary persecution* — “Tribulation.” *Orge* is the Greek word that means God's *punishing wrath*. As Revelation 19 above explains, Christ brings God's (orge) wrath when Christ comes

“He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”

— **Revelation 19:15**

How so many pastors and teachers missed this is beyond comprehension!

This next section refines what we've just seen — focusing on deeper roots behind the errors:

1. Pre-Tribulational Rapture claims: Jesus returns secretly before a seven-year tribulation to *snatch away* the Church.

What the Bible teaches: Jesus returns **once**, *after* the tribulation, visibly and gloriously.

Matthew 24:29-31 — *“Immediately after the tribulation of those days... Then the sign of the Son of Man will appear in heaven, ... all the tribes of the earth will mourn, and they will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven with power and great glory. And...his angels will gather his elect from the four winds,...”*

1 Thessalonians 4:16-17 — The “gathering” is not a snatch-and-run escape—this is royal reception language (Gr. *apantesis*) welcoming Jesus back to the earth, the returning victorious King. Cf. Palm

Sunday's crowd went out, met, and escorted King Jesus back into the city. And so it will be on the day of His (Gr. *parousia*) Second Coming.

2. Dispensationalism claims: God has two distinct peoples: Israel and the Church.

What the Bible teaches: One People, united through one Messiah.

Ephesians 2:14-16 — *“He...made us both one and has broken down in His flesh the dividing wall of hostility by abolishing the law...one new man in place of the two, so making peace.”*

Romans 11:17-23 — *“...a wild olive shoot,...grafted in among the others and now share in the nourishing root...do not be arrogant...proud, but fear. ... they (Messianics) will be grafted back in.*

Galatians 3:29 — *“...if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise.”*

The Church is the fulfillment of Israel's destiny to bless the nations.

3. That “Heaven” is our Final Destination

What it claims: Our souls go to heaven forever.

What the Bible teaches: The final hope is *resurrection* and a *renewed earth*. Christ, the firstfruit — the resurrected righteous share in Christ's first resurrection.

Romans 8:22-23 — *“the firstfruits of the Spirit...wait eagerly for adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies.*

Titus 2:13 — *“...our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great god and Savior Jesus Christ,...”*

Revelation 21:2-3 — *“...new Jerusalem..., ‘Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.”*

Sheol's Paradise is temporary. The restoration of all things and the new Jerusalem are permanent.

4. The Immortal Soul Doctrine asserts that all souls are inherently immortal.

What the Bible teaches: Immortality is a *gift* given through Christ to the righteous — immortal, glorified bodies “like Jesus” on the day of the Lord.

1 Timothy 6:16 — “...*the blessed and only Sovereign, the King of kings and Lord of lords, ...alone has immortality...*”

Romans 6:23 — “...*the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.*”

Without resurrection or “changing,” there is no eternal life.

The gospel is not about escaping the material world. It’s about restoring it.

5. Gnostic Influences claims: The material world is evil.

What the Bible teaches: Creation is good.

Genesis 1:31 — “*And God saw everything He made, and behold, it was very good.*”

John 1:14 — “*And the Word became flesh, ...we have seen His glory...grace and truth.*”

Luke 24:39 — “*See my hands and my feet, that it is I myself. Touch me, and see. For a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.*”

1 Corinthians 15:52 — “...*in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet...the dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. For this perishable body must put on the imperishable, and this mortal body must put on immortality.*”

Summary: Let Scripture Shape the Framework

Many of us inherited sincere teaching — but sincerity is not the standard. Truth is found in God’s Word, rightly understood.

The early church proclaimed:

- Resurrection hope
- Covenant faithfulness

- Kingdom on earth
- New creation through Christ

"The unfolding of your words gives light; it imparts understanding to the simple."

— **Psalm 119:130**



Reflect & Discuss

1. Which of these "popular errors" have you encountered in your upbringing, church life, or Christian culture?
2. Why is it crucial to distinguish Christ's peaceful entry into Jerusalem from His future return at the Parousia? How does mixing them up distort our expectations?
3. How can you test sermons, books, and teachers against Scripture?

BLANK PAGE FOR YOUR NOTES

RESOURCES FOR HONEST BIBLE STUDY

TOOLS, HABITS, AND STUDY METHODS FOR
READING THE BIBLE WITHOUT FILTERED
ASSUMPTIONS

If we want to recover the biblical worldview, we need more than good intentions. We need tools, habits, and most of all, we need to approach Scripture with humility and hunger—the kind that says, “Lord, open my eyes.”

“Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law.”

— Psalm 119:18

This chapter provides a practical guide to study methods, translation tools, and discernment principles to empower you to dig deeper and test the Word.

Bible Study Tools You Should Know

- **BibleHub.com** — A FREE, powerful site with interlinear Hebrew and Greek concordances, word studies, and parallel translations. Great for cross-referencing original terms.

- **BlueLetterBible.org** — A robust online tool with word parsing, commentaries, and Strong's integration. Includes lexicons, grammar notes, and search filters.
- **StepBible.org** (from Tyndale House) — Intuitive. Shows real-time word links to original texts, with definitions and usage stats.
- **Logos (Faithlife)** — Premium software used by scholars and pastors alike. Excellent for those serious about deep, long-term study and for building a digital theological library.
- **Thompson Chain-Reference Bible**
- **NET Bible Full Notes Edition**
- **Strong's Concordance**
- **Vine's Expository Dictionary**
- **Theological Wordbook of the Old Testament (TWOT)**
- **New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology and Exegesis (NIDNTTE)**

Beware the Filter: English Translation Is Not Neutral

No English Bible is a word-for-word replica of the original Hebrew or Greek. For that matter, neither is the Septuagint (LXX). Every translator — every translation — makes interpretive choices. And sometimes, those choices reflect doctrinal bias or theological tradition more than linguistic accuracy.

Common Translation Pitfalls

1. “Hell” in the Old Testament

The word *Sheol* appears dozens of times in the Hebrew Bible. It simply means “grave” or “the realm of the dead” — but many English versions translate it as “hell,” especially in the notorious KJV, which imports ideas that the original text never intended. Example: Psalm 16:10 — “You will not abandon my soul to hell...” (KJV) But in Hebrew, it is *Sheol* — *the grave, or the realm of the dead*. And that could mean Paradise, or Hades.

Careful translation reveals there are **two compartments of Sheol divided by a chasm**.

Paradise is the temporary waiting place for the souls and spirits of the righteous who have died a mortal death. In Paradise, they await their resurrection — on the day of the Lord when Christ returns to the earth.

Hades (“hell”) is the temporary place of torment that the unrighteous occupy. In Hades, they await the Great White Throne judgment and eternity in the lake of fire.

2. “Heaven” in Genesis 1:1

The Hebrew word *shamayim* means **sky or the visible heavens**, not God’s heavenly abode. Yet many readers assume Genesis 1 is referring to God’s spiritual home. Misleading translations feed that assumption.

3. “Forever” Doesn’t Always Mean Eternal

The Hebrew word *olam* often means “for a long duration” or “as long as the conditions apply.” Many modern versions translate it as “forever,” even when the context suggests otherwise (like priestly service or temple rituals).

4. “Church” Replacing “Assembly”

The Greek word *ekklesia* means “assembly” or “called-out ones.” However, English translators rendered it “church,” a word that now carries institutional and hierarchical baggage not present in the first century.

A Simple Method for Testing English Translations

- **Compare translations:** Use 2–3 English versions side-by-side (e.g., ESV, NASB, LSB, or YLT).
- **Use interlinear tools:** Check original words on BibleHub or Blue Letter Bible.
- **Look up word frequency:** See how consistently a term is translated.
- **Watch for italics:** In KJV and NASB, these indicate words added by translators for clarity — not found in the original.
- **Ask the question:** “Is this word being translated or interpreted?”

Study Habits That Invite Truth

- **Slow Down** - Don’t race through the Bible. Meditate. Pause. Let Scripture interpret Scripture.
- **Ask Better Questions** - Instead of “What does this mean to me?” ask: “What did this mean to the original audience?” And, “How does this fit in the covenant story?”
- **Invite Correction** - Truth-seekers are teachable. Let it win if the word you looked up challenges what you’ve always believed.

“Give instruction to a wise man, and he will be still wiser; teach a righteous man, and he will increase in learning.”

— Proverbs 9:9

- **Commit to Context** - Don't build theology on fragments. Read before and after. Trace the narrative. Try to comprehend the context and culture of the original target audience.

The Goal Is Not Just Knowledge — It's Alignment

Honest Bible study is about accuracy, not about being right. It's about becoming aligned with God's redemptive plan, His heart, and His coming Kingdom.

"Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth."

— 2 Timothy 2:15

- **A Bible scholar's goal** is not to affirm what we've been told, but to discover what God truly said —Bible Truth!
- **Truth seekers are not afraid** of questions or intimidated by pressure to maintain an error-filled status quo.

So keep asking, keep searching, and let the Word of God reshape your understanding of its framework.



Reflect & Discuss

1. **How has the original Hebrew or Greek wording clarified (or corrected) a previously held assumption in your theology?** Can you provide a specific example involving terms such as *Sheol*, *parousia*, or *hell*?
2. **Of the common English translation pitfalls discussed, which surprised you most?**
3. **How can believers guard against theological bias in their tools or translations?** What practical steps can be taken to “test all things”?
4. **What does it mean to let Scripture define its framework?** How might this principle shape the way you approach future Bible study?

LET SCRIPTURE DEFINE YOUR FRAMEWORK

AN INVITATION TO LIFELONG REFORMATION
IN LIGHT OF GOD'S REDEMPITIVE PLAN

If you've made it this far, you're not content with clichés — you want Bible Truth, even when it disrupts old assumptions. And that's precisely what Scripture was always meant to do.

“For the word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword... discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart.”

— **Hebrews 4:12**

This book did not set out to teach a new theology. It invited you to recover the ancient worldview that the prophets proclaimed, that Jesus fulfilled, and that the apostles preached.

Reclaiming the Framework

The goal wasn't merely better information. The goal was, and remains — to empower readers like you to seek, find, and recover God's original framework: a covenantal, kingdom-oriented relationship between God and His people.

As one of my patients once told me years ago,

“You know, doc — I’ve read the Bible 39 times, and every time I discover new things I had never realized before.”

Now, I can pass along the same realization:

“Every time I read Scripture, I am awed by what I hadn’t seen before.”

Now go out and share your discoveries with your family, friends — and the whole world!

From Eden to New Jerusalem

From Adam’s fall to our King’s return
From presuppositions to new revelations
The Good News is this:

“Jesus came. He’s coming again!”

“And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, ‘Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be His people — and God Himself will be with them as their God.’”

— Revelation 21:3



BIBLE STUDY IN A WORLD OF MISINFORMATION

GUARDING AGAINST THEOLOGICAL DRIFT AND DOCTRINAL ASSUMPTIONS

We live in an age of biblical soundbites and spiritual slogans.
Social media rewards brevity, not accuracy.

Pulpits often prioritize feel-good inspiration over truthful Bible instruction.

Popular devotionals — sweet and well-meaning though they may be — sometimes substitute opinions instead of faithful exposition.

Biblical literacy is not optional — it is the only safeguard against spiritual drift in an age of misinformation. As **Hosea 4:6** says...

“My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge...”

Theological drift begins with a misunderstanding of God’s Word. It begins with small assumptions — a word mistranslated, a verse removed from its context, a doctrine inherited but never examined. Over time, these distortions form a framework — a lens — that reshapes how we read the entire Bible.

Common Misinformation Patterns

- **Emotional Interpretation Over Textual Authority** — *“That verse speaks to me.”*
- **Proof-text Without Context** — When a single verse is pulled to support a false doctrine without consideration of its context. People approach me with erroneous statements all the time — something they’ve heard repeatedly and “take for gospel.” Whoever misinformed them could have avoided many divisive issues in today’s churches had they only continued to read the following one or two sentences.
- **Silencing the Old Testament** — There is barely a sentence in Revelation that you won’t find in the Old Testament prophets and Psalms.
- **Overconfidence in Commentaries and Study Notes** — Never allow commentary to supersede Scripture.
- **Confusing Church Tradition With Apostolic Teaching** — A theological error that’s been popular for 100 years might not be biblical at all. Test everything!

How to Guard Against Doctrinal Drift

- **Read With Humility** — Begin with the assumption that you may be wrong.
- **Return to the Original Languages** — Use interlinear tools—Hebrew and Greek. Dig for truth!
- **Let Scripture Interpret Scripture** — Don’t pit verses against each other. Look for the patterns across the covenants.
- **Don’t Outsource Your Theology** —Commentaries can sometimes be helpful, but we must never base our faith in someone’s opinion in place of our study. Seek the Lord in the text, not just the footnotes.
- **Test Every Teaching** — **Especially the Familiar Ones that people always quote.** Familiarity is not proof of truth. Test it all.

The world is full of voices claiming to speak for God. But only one Voice spoke the heavens into being.

Only one Word became flesh. Only one Spirit leads us into all truth. If ever there was a time to return to The Good Book — that time is *now*!



BLANK PAGE FOR YOUR NOTES

FINAL THOUGHTS: THE RETURN OF OUR KING

A GLIMPSE INTO THE RESTORATION SERIES:
FOUNDATIONS OF THE WORLD TO THE
RENEWAL OF ALL THINGS

The *Restoration Series* isn't just about correcting misunderstandings. It's about recovering the glorious story God has been telling from the beginning.

When Christ returns on the Day of the Lord, the process of making all things new again begins.

Restoration of the Word Precedes Restoration of the World

*You've just begun the journey of recovering a biblical worldview. What follows is a glimpse into the broader landscape of restoration — a foretaste of the truths we will explore together in the coming volumes of *The Restoration Series*.*

In the world of social media, influencers' primary objective is to reshape their followers' worldview. In the world of religious denominations, a similar yet distinct phenomenon occurs.

Presuppositions tend to distort God's story. They can minimize or

disguise God's covenantal love, or reshape His Word into something unrecognizable.

Presuppositions shape our understanding of "the gospel," "the church," "heaven," and "the end times."

The Day of the Lord will *not* be the evacuation of saints but the return of the King. There is no pre-tribulation rapture or escape of the Church to God's abode. Test what you've been taught against the very words spoken by Jesus...

*"No one has ascended into heaven except He who descended from heaven,
the Son of Man."*

— **John 3:13**

*"You will seek me, and just as I said to the Jews, so now I also say to you,
'Where I am going you cannot come.'"*

— **John 13:33**

"And when He had said these things, as they were looking on, He was lifted up, and a cloud took Him out of their sight. And while they were gazing into heaven as He went, behold, two men stood by them in white robes and said,

"Men of Galilee, why do you stand looking into heaven? This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw Him go into heaven."

— **Acts 1:9–11**

"I saw in the night visions, and behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and He came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before Him. And to Him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve Him; His dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and His kingdom one that shall not be destroyed."

— **Daniel 7:13–14**

NOTE: Remember, whenever the Bible reads “peoples, nations, and languages,” it speaks of the earth — not God’s celestial abode.

When God created “the heavens and the earth,” He was not making “Heaven” as many have imagined. God was creating the shamayim and the aretz — *the heavens and the earth*.

The heavens and the earth are a unified creation — land below, sky above — designed for fellowship between God and humanity.

Where is Jesus Today?

Today, Jesus remains in the heavenly realm, awaiting His return to the earth. Soon, He will descend — not to snatch and run, but to stay and reign.

The Cloud Rider and The Covenant Maker

Jesus is the Cloud Rider — the Son of Man who ascended to the Ancient of Days and will return with the clouds of heaven (**Daniel 7:13-14; Revelation 1:7**).

The Father is the Covenant Maker — the One who swore by Himself, who keeps every promise.

“But He remained silent and made no answer. Again, the high priest asked Him, ‘Are You the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?’ And Jesus said, ‘I am, and you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven.’”

— **Mark 14:61-62**

“Behold, the Lord is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt; and the idols of Egypt will tremble at his presence, and the heart of the Egyptians will melt within them.”

— **Isaiah 19:1**

Differentiate Between the Tree of Life and the Olive Tree

The Olive Tree represents Israel, the covenant people — a living symbol of God's promises made through Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Paul affirms this in **Romans 11:17-24**, where believing Gentiles are grafted into this cultivated tree.

But the tree's root is not Israel — it's God, the Covenant Maker. He is the one who sustains and nourishes all things.

When Jesus cursed the fruitless olive tree in **Matthew 21** and **Mark 11:12-14**, He issued a prophetic judgment against unbelieving Israel — He was not abolishing the tree itself. The tree wasn't uprooted. It was condemned for a time — a picture of judgment for a season of unfaithfulness.

Paul says, “*God has not rejected His people whom He foreknew*” (**Romans 11:2**). The tree remains. One day soon, (**Romans 11:26**), all of Israel will be saved and grafted back in.



Tree of Life

*A symbol of the Holy Spirit's
presence and the
restoration of all things.
(Acts 3:21)*

The Tree of Life is not national—it's universal. It represented God's Spirit in Eden; it is currently in Paradise; and it will soon to be found in New Jerusalem. The Tree of Life represents the **life-giving presence of God** — available to all who are righteous. Those who eat the fruit of it will live forever (**Genesis 3:22, Revelation 22:14**)



ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Jim & Sandy Gosney and Lane and Kathy Elliott

As I launch this *The Restoration Series*, I want to pause and offer heartfelt thanks to two long-time friends and fellow students of Scripture — Jim Gosney and Lane Elliott.

Jim has faithfully proofread the majority of articles I've published at *TheMission.Today* — and anything else I sent him. Jim's wife, Sandy, has been a constant encouragement and a loyal friend to Jeanne. Their kindness has meant more than words can say.

Lane and his wife, Kathy, graciously opened their home in San Juan Capistrano for our Wednesday Night Bible Studies, offering hospitality, wisdom, and warm fellowship for many years. Though they now reside in Oregon, Lane continues to teach the Bible.

To each of you: "Thank you!" Your prayers made this work possible.

Jeanne

And now, I come to the love of my life — Jeanne. From the very beginning, she has been more than my partner — she's been my compass. We launched our journey aboard a sailboat, living on the sea and chasing the horizon.

While I am the captain, Jeanne was never just a first mate — she's

been the steady hand that made my lifelong dream of long-distance sailing with our family a reality.

Jeanne homeschooled our two boys with a diverse, comprehensive curriculum. She ensured they attended top universities and shaped them into thoughtful, loving, grounded, Christian men. I'm proud to call them "my sons."

She did all this while we were serving overseas, gracefully navigating unfamiliar languages and cultures. Whether in Kenya, Spain, or anywhere else, Jeanne made every place we landed feel like home.

We've since become pilgrims of a different kind — trekking ancient Roman roads on the Camino de Santiago, carrying not just backpacks but decades of memories.

Our most recent sailboat—the one Jeanne named "Spirit of Hope"—was sold too long ago. But the name still fits. That's what she's given me all these years: a *spirit of hope*.

Thank you!



A GLIMPSE AHEAD:
THE TREE OF LIFE AND THE RESTORATION OF
ALL THINGS

The Tree of Life and the Restoration of All Things

Throughout Scripture, the Tree of Life appears at the story's beginning, middle, and end.

It stood in Eden's garden. It now stands in Paradise, where the righteous await resurrection. And at the end of Christ's Millennial Reign, it will flourish for eternity in the New Jerusalem.

The *Restoration Series* invites you to journey deeper:

From the dust of Genesis to the river of Revelation, discovering God's unbroken covenant to dwell with His people forever.

The Tree of Life is not a myth. It is the beating heart of redemptive history.



Tree of Life

*A symbol of the Holy Spirit's
presence and the
restoration of all things.
(Acts 3:21)*

The Restoration Series

Recovering the Biblical Worldview of God's Redemptive Plan

by Dr. Tim James

1. Presuppositions

Recovering the Biblical Worldview of God's Redemptive Plan

The foundation of all theological understanding. Identifies unseen assumptions, dismantles flawed paradigms, and equips readers to read Scripture with clarity, context, and confidence.

2. Tree of Life

From Eden to Paradise to the New Jerusalem

Explores the Tree of Life as a metaphor for the Holy Spirit — tracing its presence from Eden to Sheol's Paradise to New Jerusalem. Offers a fresh perspective on God's abiding presence across time and space.

3. Wake Up!

The Bridegroom Approaches

Matthew Chapter 25 contains two parables and a prophecy. The second parable and the prophecy fit hand-in-glove. However, the first — The Parable of the Ten Virgins — is one of the most commonly misunderstood parables in the Bible. Not for long, though!

4. The Day of The Lord

God's Love, His Covenants, and the Coming Kingdom

An in-depth theological and prophetic exploration of Christ's return, His retrieval of the remnant, the culmination of God's redemptive plan, and the final judgment. Refutes the pre-tribulational rapture and restores the biblical timeline of resurrection and rule.

5. Jerusalem!

The City of the Great King and the Climax of Redemption

An eschatological and historical celebration of Jerusalem's past, present, and future. From prophets to today to New Jerusalem.

Reveals how the city of David becomes the location of the throne of Christ — where heaven meets earth, and eternity begins.

6. Death Is an Unnatural Intruder

The Divine Revolt Against Mortality and the Hope of Resurrection

A deeply theological and pastoral study of death and resurrection. Traces God's redemptive arc from Eden to the First Resurrection, restoring hope in the bodily return of the righteous.

7. The Role of Israel in the End of the Age

Traces Israel's redemptive arc through tribulation, deliverance, and national rebirth. Explains how the Jewish people will be grafted back in, baptized as a nation, and restored to covenant faithfulness.

8. Worship and the Reign of Christ (*in development*)

A creative, immersive vision of life during the Millennial Kingdom. It explores glorified saints, restored geography, and the ongoing worship of the King in Jerusalem.

GLOSSARY OF KEY BIBLICAL TERMS

Apantesis (ἀπάντησις)

A Greek term meaning “to meet” or “go out to receive.” Used in **1 Thessalonians 4:17** to describe the saints meeting Christ in the air — not to depart permanently, but to welcome Him as He returns to reign.

Covenant (Hebrew: *berith*)

A divinely initiated promise or agreement, often confirmed with signs, sacrifices, or ceremonies. God's covenants are unbreakable and reveal His redemptive plan throughout Scripture — culminating in the New Covenant through Christ.

Day of the Lord (Hebrew: *yom YHWH*)

A prophetic term for the climactic return of Jesus in judgment and glory. It is not a secret rapture but a visible, earth-shaking event that restores God's Kingdom and vindicates the righteous.

Ebrah (עֲבָרָה)

A Hebrew term meaning “fury” or “indignation.” One of the key

biblical words describing God's wrath — especially in prophetic or eschatological contexts (e.g., **Isaiah 13:9**, **Zephaniah 3:8**).

Episunagōgē (ἐπισυναγωγή)

Greek for “gathering together” — used in **2 Thessalonians 2:1** to describe the assembling of believers to Christ at His coming. Distinct from a secret removal, it's a public and prophetic reunion.

Ha-aretz (אֶרֶץ)

Hebrew for “the earth.” Frequently paired with ha-shamayim (“the heavens”) as a merism — indicating the totality of creation (e.g., **Genesis 1:1**, **Psalms 115:15**).

Sheol

Sheol is *a real, spiritual realm*—the unseen realm of the dead—described throughout the Old Testament. It is compartmentalized into Paradise (rest for the righteous) and Hades (torment for the unrighteous). The first judgment occurs immediately upon the death of the human body. The Great White Throne Judgment is a different, final judgment that occurs later.

In the inner earth (**Luke 16:19-31**) and numerous verses as *well*, Sheol consists of two compartments separated by a chasm :

Paradise — The peaceful compartment within Sheol where the souls of the righteous await the resurrection. It is described in **Luke 16** and affirmed by Jesus in **Luke 23:43**.

Hades — The torment side of Sheol. It is often used in the New Testament to describe the condition of the unrighteous dead awaiting the Great White Throne Judgment. Not synonymous with Sheol itself.

Paradise and Hades are separated by a fixed chasm (**Luke 16:19-31**). Both are temporary waiting places: The righteous await resurrection on the Day of the Lord. The wicked await final judgment and the lake of fire.

NOTE: The human consists of a body, soul, and spirit. The spirit provides our identity, whether in a body or not. This author concludes that once the body of a righteous human dies, their soul—their spiritual point of communion with God — remains linked to their spirit (a soul-spirit complex). The unrighteous, who are already condemned to damnation (separation from God), no longer need nor possess a soul. Nevertheless, their spiritual identity remains until the lake of fire.

Harpazo – The “snatching away” or catching away of believers. It’s a grossly misinterpreted, mistranslated verb that is more akin to something Satan would do than Jesus Christ. Look it up on biblehub.com and see for yourself. The pretribulationists who follow Darby-Scofield’s dispensationalism cling to the delusion that it implies Christ’s secretly snatching them to Heaven. However, as shown throughout this series, **John 3:13** and **John 13:33** altogether nix any such possibility. **1 Thessalonians 4:17** describes what was foreshadowed on Palm Sunday - the crowd rushed out to meet their king, were gathered to Him, and followed Him back into the city where they will live and reign with Him here, on Earth, forever and ever.

Glorification – The final transformation of believers into resurrected, immortal bodies “like Christ’s.”

Immortality – The state of incorruptible life, granted to the righteous at the resurrection of the righteous dead and the “changing” of the righteous alive.

Kingdom – The reign of God manifests when Christ returns to the earth and begins to reign from His (earthly father David's) throne at Mount Zion, Jerusalem. That will mark the fulfillment of the Davidic Covenant.

Orge – The punishing, judicial wrath of God. Reserved for the Day of the Lord, when Christ brings the bowls of God's wrath upon His return in the parousia. At the crucifixion, the Father cast His wrath against sin upon Jesus. When Christ returns, it will be His turn to cast the Father's wrath upon all those who reject Jesus Christ.

Parousia – The visible, triumphant arrival of Christ at the end of the age. It marks the Second Resurrection and the gathering of the saints.

Resurrection – The bodily restoration of the dead. The first resurrection was Christ's. The second resurrection will include all the righteous at the Day of the Lord. The unrighteous will rise later for judgment.

Soul – The seat of human identity and communion with God. The soul can be preserved in righteousness or lost in separation.

Spirit – The eternal essence or identity of a person. While the soul communes with God, the spirit reflects eternal personhood. The unrighteous may lose their soul but retain their spirit until final judgment.

Thymos – The passionate expression of God's anger. Used in Revelation to describe the intensity of His righteous judgment.



APPENDIX A - SIX MAJOR COVENANTS

God's Biblical Covenants

A covenant is a divine promise—an agreement initiated by God, grounded in His unchanging character.

Though humans may fail, God never revokes His word. He may discipline, delay, or redirect, but never breaks a covenant.

Scripture shows a series of redemptive promises that unfold God's plan to dwell with His people.

These covenants are not isolated—they build upon one another, moving from Eden to Zion, from Adam to Christ.

The Edenic Covenant

Genesis 1:27-30; Genesis 2:15-17

God created humanity in His image and placed them in a garden sanctuary.

Even after Adam and Eve rebelled, God hinted at redemption—the promise of a seed to overcome the serpent and restore creation.

The Noahic Covenant

Genesis 8:20-9:17

Following the flood, God made a universal promise never again to destroy the earth with water.

He established the rainbow as a sign of His enduring mercy toward all living creatures and affirmed the value of life and the stability of creation.

The Abrahamic Covenant

Genesis 12:1-3; Genesis 15:18-19; Genesis 17:1-21; Deuteronomy 28:1-14; Deuteronomy 29; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Zephaniah 3:11-13; Hebrews 10:1-18

God called Abram out of the nations to form a people through whom all nations would be blessed.

This covenant promised the land, offspring, and a global inheritance.

Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.

The Mosaic Covenant

Exodus 19:1-25; Exodus 20:1-21; Deuteronomy 4:1-14

God formalized His relationship with Israel at Sinai through law, worship, and priesthood.

This covenant structured the chosen people, calling them to holiness, obedience, and love for God and neighbor.

The Davidic Covenant

2 Samuel 23:1-7; 1 Chronicles 17; 2 Chronicles 7; 2 Chronicles 13:5; Psalm 89:3-4; Jeremiah 33:20-26

God chose David's line to bear the promise of kingship.

This covenant foretold a Son who would reign forever — a righteous King whose dominion would never end and whose throne would be established on Mount Zion.

The New Covenant

Isaiah 42:6; 49:8-13; 54:10; 56:1-7; 61:8-9; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Ezekiel 36:22-38; Matthew 1:17-18, 23; 2:3-6; 16:13-19; 26:26-29; Luke 22:20; John 1:9-14; 7:32-36, 40-44; 10:22-39; Acts 2:14-47; Acts 3; Romans 1:18-32; 3:21-31; 9:22-29; 11:25-32; 2 Corinthians 1:16-22; 11:24-28; Galatians 4:21-31; Ephesians 1:7-14; Colossians 1:9-14; 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12; 1 Timothy 1:12-17; 2 Timothy 2:8-13; Hebrews 8:6; 9:11-28; 11-12; 13:20-21; 1 Peter 2:4-10; 2 Peter 3:9-13; 1 John 1:5-7; Revelation 5:1-5; 7:13-17; 22:16

The New Covenant, inaugurated by Christ, fulfills all previous covenants.

It is written on hearts, not on stones.

It offers forgiveness, Spirit-indwelling, resurrection hope, and kingdom inheritance.

Jesus is the mediator and fulfillment of this covenant—uniting Israel and the nations in one redemptive plan.



Endnotes – Appendix A: Six Covenants and Their Scriptural Foundations

Genesis 1:26-30 – God creates humanity in His image, gives them dominion over creation, and commands them to be fruitful and multiply.¹

Genesis 2:7-9 – God forms man from dust, breathes life into him, and plants a garden with the Tree of Life and the Tree of Knowledge.²

Genesis 2:15-17 – God commands Adam to work the garden and forbids eating from the Tree of Knowledge — the first moral law.³

Genesis 2:19-14 – A river flows from Eden and divides into four rivers, suggesting Eden's elevated geography and divine origin.⁴

Genesis 3:15-17 – The consequences of sin: pain in childbirth, male-female tension, and cursed ground — but also the first Messianic prophecy.⁵

Genesis 6:18 – God promises to establish His covenant with Noah and preserve him and his family through the flood.⁶

Genesis 8:20-22 – After the flood, Noah offers sacrifices; God promises never again to destroy all life and affirms His mercy despite human sin.⁷

Genesis 9:1-17 – God blesses Noah, commands fruitfulness, and establishes the rainbow as the sign of His everlasting covenant never to flood the earth again.⁸

Isaiah 54:9-10 – God compares His enduring covenant of peace to His promise to Noah: never again to flood the earth.⁹

Genesis 12:1-3 – God calls Abram to leave his homeland, promising to make him a great nation and bless all nations through him.¹⁰

Genesis 13:14-17 – God promises Abram that his descendants will inherit the land as an everlasting possession.¹¹

Genesis 17:1-8 – God confirms the covenant with Abraham, institutes circumcision, and promises him a multitude of nations and the land of Canaan forever.¹²

Genesis 22:15-18 – After Abraham's obedience, God swears an oath: his offspring will multiply and all nations will be blessed through him.¹³

Exodus 2:24-25 – God hears Israel’s groaning in Egypt and remembers His covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.¹⁴

Exodus 3:6-10 – At the burning bush, God reveals Himself to Moses as the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob and prepares to deliver Israel.¹⁵

Psalms 105:8-11 – The psalmist recounts God’s covenant with Abraham, reaffirmed to Isaac and Jacob, and the promise of the land of Canaan.¹⁶

Luke 1:72-75 – Zechariah proclaims that God has remembered His covenant with Abraham to deliver His people and enable holy service.¹⁷

Exodus 19:3-6 – God offers Israel a covenant: if they obey, they will be His treasured possession and a kingdom of priests.¹⁸

Exodus 24:3-8 – Israel agrees to the covenant terms; blood is sprinkled on the people — a formal ratification of the covenant (betrothal ceremony).¹⁹

Deuteronomy 4:12-14 — God spoke His covenant aloud at Horeb—the Ten Commandments—and charged Moses to teach them.²⁰

Deuteronomy 5:1-22 recounts the Ten Commandments; it emphasizes the covenant as a present-tense relationship with the current generation.²¹

Deuteronomy 6:1-9 – The Shema: Love the Lord with all your heart; teach these commands diligently to your children.²²

Jeremiah 11:1-5: God reminds Israel of the conditions of the Mosaic covenant—obedience would result in blessing and inheritance.²³

2 Samuel 7:8-16 – God promises David an eternal dynasty — a son who will reign forever and build a house for His name.²⁴

1 Chronicles 17:11-14 – Echoes the promise of a royal descendant: “I will establish his throne forever... he shall be to me a son.”²⁵

Psalms 89:3-4 – God swears to David: “I will establish your offspring forever, and build your throne for all generations.”²⁶

Isaiah 9:6-7 – Prophecy of the Messiah: a child born to reign on David’s throne with justice and peace forever.²⁷

Jeremiah 33:17-26 – The Lord reaffirms His eternal covenant: “David shall never lack a man to sit on the throne of Israel.”²⁸

Luke 1:31-33 – Gabriel tells Mary her son will be given the throne of David, and his kingdom will have no end.²⁹

Jeremiah 31:31-34 – The promise of a New Covenant: God will write His law on their hearts and be their God.³⁰

Ezekiel 36:25-27 – God will gather His people, cleanse them, and give them a new heart and spirit.³¹

Luke 22:20 – At the Last Supper, Jesus declares the cup is the New Covenant in His blood.³²

2 Corinthians 3:6 – Believers are ministers of a new covenant — not written in ink but by the Spirit.³³

Hebrews 8:6-13 – Jesus is the High Priest of a better covenant, enacted on better promises.³⁴

Hebrews 9:15 – Christ mediates a new covenant through His sacrificial blood.³⁵

Hebrews 10:16-18 – God’s promise to remember sins no more — Christ’s once-for-all sacrifice completes it.³⁶



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APPENDIX B: “IN THAT DAY” AND “AT THAT TIME”

PROPHETIC MARKERS OF CHRIST’S PAROUSIA

A recurring phrase throughout Scripture is “in that day” or “on that day.” It signals prophetic moments—turning points in the history of redemption. That phrase almost always refers to the Day of the Lord when Christ returns (parousia). Below is a curated list of notable references:

“In that day” / “On that day”

Isaiah

- **Isaiah 2:11** – “The haughty looks of man shall be brought low... and the Lord alone will be exalted *in that day*.”¹
- **Isaiah 4:1** – “*In that day* seven women shall take hold of one man...”¹
- **Isaiah 4:2** – “*In that day* the branch of the Lord shall be beautiful and glorious...”¹
- **Isaiah 10:20** – “*In that day* the remnant of Israel... will lean on the Lord...”¹
- **Isaiah 11:10** – “*In that day* the root of Jesse... shall stand as a signal for the peoples...”¹

- **Isaiah 12:1, 4** – “You will say *in that day*, ‘I will give thanks to you, O Lord...’”¹
- **Isaiah 17:4** – “*In that day* the glory of Jacob will be brought low...”¹
- **Isaiah 19:21** – “*And the Lord will make Himself known to the Egyptians, and the Egyptians will know the Lord *in that day*...”¹
- **Isaiah 19:24** – “*In that day* Israel will be the third with Egypt and Assyria...”¹
- **Isaiah 26:1** – “*In that day* this song will be sung in the land of Judah...”¹
- **Isaiah 27:1-2** – “*In that day* the Lord... will punish Leviathan... *In that day*, ‘A pleasant vineyard, sing of it!’”¹
- **Isaiah 30:23-26** – “And *on the day* the Lord binds up the brokenness of His people... the moon will be as bright as the sun...”¹
- **Isaiah 52:6** – “Therefore, My people shall know My name. *Therefore in that day* they shall know that it is I who speak...”¹

Ezekiel

- **Ezekiel 29:21** – “*On that day* I will cause a horn to spring up for the house of Israel...”²

Zechariah

- **Zechariah 2:11** – “And many nations shall join themselves to the Lord *in that day*...”³
- **Zechariah 3:10** – “*In that day*, declares the Lord of hosts, every one of you will invite his neighbor...”³
- **Zechariah 9:16** – “*On that day* the Lord their God will save them...”³
- **Zechariah 12:3-4, 6, 8-9** – Multiple instances of “*on that day*” marking the Lord’s defense of Jerusalem.³

- **Zechariah 13:1** – “*On that day* there shall be a fountain opened...”³
- **Zechariah 14:4, 6, 8-9, 13, 20-21** – Repeated use of “*on that day*” tied to the Messiah’s return and the reshaping of Jerusalem.³

These prophetic markers orient the reader toward climactic fulfillment. “In that day” points to God’s direct intervention—often in judgment, sometimes in blessing, always in sovereignty.

“At That Time”

Jeremiah

- **Jeremiah 3:17** – “*At that time* Jerusalem shall be called the throne of the Lord...”⁴
- **Jeremiah 30:7** – “*At that time...* it is a time of distress for Jacob...”⁴
- **Jeremiah 50:20** – “*At that time*, declares the Lord, iniquity shall be sought in Israel, and there shall be none...”⁴

Daniel

- **Daniel 12:1** – “*At that time* shall arise Michael...and there shall be a time of trouble...”⁵

Zephaniah

- **Zephaniah 3:19-20** – “*At that time* I will deal with all your oppressors... *At that time*, I will bring you in...”⁶

Matthew

- **Matthew 24:10** – “*At that time* many will fall away and betray one another...”⁷

- **Matthew 25:1** – “*At that time* the kingdom of heaven will be like ten virgins...”⁷

These passages frame the events surrounding the Day of the Lord. Whether speaking of judgment or restoration, they signal God’s sovereign action—*at that time, on that day, in that day*—and draw the reader into the final arc of His redemptive plan.

These verses highlight God’s appointed times: judgment, mercy, and restoration.

Endnotes

1. Isaiah 2:11; 4:1-2; 10:20; 11:10; 12:1,4; 17:4; 19:21,24; 26:1; 27:1-2; 30:23-26; 52:6
2. Ezekiel 29:21
3. Zechariah 2:11; 3:10; 9:16; 12:3-4,6,8-9; 13:1; 14:4,6,8-9,13,20-21
4. Jeremiah 3:17; 30:7; 50:20
5. Daniel 12:1
6. Zephaniah 3:19-20
7. Matthew 24:10; 25:1



APPENDIX C: THE UP/DN SCRIPTURAL JOURNEY OF THE DEAD

SHEOL IS DOWN. THE EARTH'S SURFACE IS UP.

No One Ascends to Heaven at Death

No human ascends to heaven at death. All descend (DN) to Sheol, and the righteous await resurrection (UP) when Christ returns.

- **John 3:13** – “No one has ascended into heaven except the One who came from heaven.”
- **Genesis 37:35** – Jacob expected to descend to Sheol.
- **Numbers 16:30–33** – Korah and followers went down alive.
- **Psalm 30:3** – David: “O LORD, You have brought up my soul from Sheol.”
- **Matthew 12:40** – Jesus descends to Sheol’s Paradise.
- **Ephesians 4:9–10** – Christ alone ascends.
- **1 Thessalonians 4:16–17** – Resurrection occurs at His return.
- **Hebrews 11:35–40** – Righteous patriarchs awaited resurrection.

NOTE: Sheol is the underworld where all disembodied spirits temporarily reside.

- Paradise = the righteous side awaiting the First resurrection and eternity with God.
- Hades = the unrighteous side awaiting the Second resurrection and the eternal lake of fire judgment.

Some English translations confusingly render *Sheol* as *Hades*; In this work, the author rejects that equivalence. Also, do not confuse Hades (a.k.a. “hell”) with Gehenna (final destruction/lake of fire) or the Abyss/Tartarus (angelic prison).

UP/DN Reference Chart

#	Passage	Direction	Description
1	Genesis 37:35	DOWN	Jacob expects to descend to Sheol
2	Numbers 16:30–33	DOWN	Korah and his company go alive into Sheol
3	Psalms 138:1	UP	David brought up from Sheol
4	Isaiah 14:15	DOWN	Lucifer cast down to Sheol
5	Matthew 12:40	DOWN	Jesus in the heart of the earth (Sheol)
6	Ephesians 4:9–10	DOWN/UP	Christ descends, then ascends above the heavens
7	1 Thessalonians 4:16–17	DOWN/UP	Christ descends, dead rise to the surface
8	Hebrews 11:35–40	UP	Righteous receive a better resurrection
9	Acts 2:29, 34	DOWN	David is in Sheol’s Paradise

10	1 Enoch 22	DOWN	Sheol has hollows for righteous and wicked
11	Wisdom 16:13	DOWN/UP	God leads to Hades and brings up again

Author's usage: *Paradise* (a.k.a. Abraham's Bosom) and *Hades* are both compartments within Sheol — the underworld realm of disembodied spirits.

Further, the author maintains that spirits in Hades no longer have souls as they will no longer have a connection to God. (Spiritual Death = Separation from God.)

On the other hand, since righteous disembodied spirits will eternally be connected to God, they retain their original, purified by-the-blood-of-Christ souls. It's a concept packed with nuance, so I am not dogmatic about it—just something to consider.



THEMATIC STRUCTURE INDEX

1. God's Covenant Faithfulness

Genesis 9:9-17, Genesis 17:7, Exodus 2:24, Deuteronomy 7:9, Psalm 105:8-11, Jeremiah 31:31-34, Luke 1:72-75, Hebrews 6:13-18

2. The Promised Seed and Messiah

Genesis 3:15, Genesis 22:18, 2 Samuel 7:12-16, Isaiah 9:6-7, Luke 1:31-33, Luke 2:11, John 1:14, Romans 1:1-4

3. The Kingdom of God and David's Throne

2 Samuel 7:13-16, Psalm 89:3-4, Jeremiah 33:17-26, Isaiah 11:1-10, Luke 1:32-33, Acts 2:30-36, Revelation 5:5, Revelation 22:16

4. Sheol, Paradise, and the Righteous Dead

Genesis 37:35, 1 Samuel 28:13-15, Psalm 16:10, Isaiah 14:9, Luke 16:19-31, Luke 23:43, Ephesians 4:8-10, Revelation 6:9-11

5. Resurrection and Immortality

Isaiah 26:19, Daniel 12:2-3, John 5:28-29, John 11:25-26, Romans 8:11, 1 Corinthians 15:20-26, 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17, Revelation 20:4-6

6. The Day of the Lord and Final Judgment

Isaiah 13:9, Zephaniah 1:14-18, Joel 2:30-31, Matthew 24:29-31, 1 Thessalonians 5:2-3, 2 Thessalonians 1:7-10, Revelation 6:12-17, Revelation 20:11-15

7. New Covenant and Spirit-Indwelling

Jeremiah 31:33, Ezekiel 36:26-27, Luke 22:20, John 14:16-17, 2 Corinthians 3:6, Hebrews 8:6-13, Hebrews 10:16-18, Romans 8:9-11

AFTERWORD

If you've reached this point, you've done something rare: you've paused to examine not just what you believe — but why.

This volume is only the beginning. *The Restoration Series* continues with books on resurrection, covenant, the Tree of Life, Christ's return, and the fulfillment of God's plan.

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— *Dr. Tim James*

